

Building Vibrant Communities

Book 10

Unit 1

Accompanying One Another on the Path of Service

**PRE-PUBLICATION EDITION
MATERIAL IN DEVELOPMENT**

VERSION 1.2.1.PP

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Ruhi Institute

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Ruhi Institute
Apartado Postal: 402032
Cali, Colombia
Tel: 57 2 828-2599
Email: instituto@ruhi.org
Website: www.ruhi.org

The Ruhi Institute is an educational institution functioning under the aegis of the National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of Colombia. Its purpose is to develop human resources dedicated to the spiritual, social and cultural progress of the Colombian people. Over the decades its materials have increasingly been used by national Bahá'í communities in all parts of the world.

The approach to curriculum development followed by the Ruhi Institute differs significantly from the traditional one of design, field-testing and evaluation, carried out in a linear fashion. The first step in writing any set of materials is taken, rather, when an experience is created at the grassroots in performing some act of service in response to the exigencies of the development of a community. Materials emerge out of this experience and become an expression of it. They are, on the one hand, a record of the learning that occurs in applying the teachings of the Bahá'í Faith in a particular area of service and, on the other, an instrument for the systematization of that learning. The approach has been described in the following terms in the small volume *Learning About Growth: The story of the Ruhi Institute and large-scale expansion of the Bahá'í Faith in Colombia*:

Once an educational need is identified, a small group of people, working at the grassroots, consult among themselves, develop a set of ideas for educational activities, and put them into practice. The results of this practice are reviewed, evaluated and consulted upon; in light of this consultation, a modified set of educational activities is put into practice, and subjected to reflection that leads to further modification and revision. At no time in this process of curriculum development does action await the final preparation and evaluation of educational materials. At every stage, educational activities proceed with the best materials at hand, in the conviction that it is only through practice and reflection, both pursued in light of the Revelation of Bahá'u'lláh, that more appropriate curricula can gradually evolve. Yet, this is not a setting in which a few individuals are developing materials for their own use, and it does become necessary at some point to finalize the structure and content of each unit so that it may be used with confidence by others. The decision to release a final version of the materials for a given course is made simply when it is noticed that modifications are becoming negligible. It is important to note that the various aspects of this process of consultation, action and reflection are carried out parallel with one another, and not performed in a linear sequence which would be inherently artificial.

As the use of the materials of the Ruhi Institute has become more widespread, the development process has drawn increasingly on experience worldwide in applying the teachings to the life of humanity. Though in practice the process today can take divers forms, depending on the nature of the material in development, there are generally three stages that give rise to what is considered the final published edition.

1. Initial Outline

At this stage a course or text contains the basic concepts and a set of passages from the Bahá'í writings that, taken together, are believed to achieve the educational objective in question. For some time, this initial outline of ideas is used by small groups of individuals in the field, as part of the efforts to elaborate effective course content.

2. Alpha Version

As action progresses, the material is refined and begins to reflect new experience gained, incorporating ideas that arise out of it. Not infrequently, certain concepts are amended, new passages from the Bahá'í writings added, or a series of simple exercises introduced to

facilitate comprehension of a topic or to help develop an important skill or attitude. Through this process, a consolidated course or text emerges which is generally regarded as the “alpha version”.

3. Pre-Publication Edition

In time it is determined, generally on the basis of the integrity of the content, to make the course or text more widely available as a pre-publication edition. Through its continued use, it becomes apparent when a section needs to be moved or an exercise or two revised. Several successive versions may appear. Gradually, however, fewer and fewer modifications are required to achieve the intended purpose of the course or text, and the material, at this stage, goes for publication.

We are happy to make available to selected organizations and institutions one of the units that has reached the pre-publication stage. It is the first of three units of a book currently in development entitled *Building Vibrant Communities*. You are encouraged to send us any comments you have on the basis of your experience in using the course content.

Ruhi Institute

SECTION 1

A goal central to the books in the series we have studied thus far has been to examine the meaning of the phrase “I walk a path of service”. In one way or another, every unit of every book has been concerned with the “being”, the “doing”, and the “knowing” that help us to define the “I” and the “path of service” and that assist us in “walking” it. What the numerous passages from the writings we have explored in these units make clear is that the “I” in question does not refer to the self so glorified by the moribund society of today. Its identity and attributes are forged in the fire of the love of God; its integrity is upheld by the principle of the oneness of humankind. It is not simply “I” who walks the path of service but “we” who walk it together; “I” and “we” are, to a large extent, inseparable. For ultimately, it is the movement of entire populations towards Bahá’u’lláh’s vision of a prosperous and peaceful world civilization, one from which all of humanity will benefit, that is our concern, and the books in the series we are studying hope to contribute to the collective capacity needed to lend impetus to this movement, which, we know, is gathering momentum in all parts of the globe under the guidance of the Universal House of Justice.

In this book, then—the tenth in the series—we turn our attention to our service to the Cause of God and to humanity as a community. We begin here in the first unit by looking specifically at the nature of our relationships with one another as we labor together shoulder to shoulder. In doing so, we will draw on many of the messages written in recent decades by the House of Justice, in which it has progressively clarified for us so many fundamental concepts. Indeed, two of these, which greatly shape our interactions, will be the subject of our study and reflection in this unit: that our mode of operation as a community is one of learning and that, in the posture of learners, we are accompanying one another on the path of service to the Cause and to humanity. In order to grasp these two concepts adequately, we should strive to develop an even more profound understanding of the nature of the path on which we cultivate our capacity to serve. Let us embark on our study in this unit, then, by examining the following passage from a message dated 12 December 2011 written by the Universal House of Justice:

“The main sequence of courses is organized so as to set the individual, whether Bahá’í or not, on a path being defined by the accumulating experience of the community in its endeavor to open before humanity the vision of Bahá’u’lláh’s World Order. The very notion of a path is, itself, indicative of the nature and purpose of the courses, for a path invites participation, it beckons to new horizons, it demands effort and movement, it accommodates different paces and strides, it is structured and defined. A path can be experienced and known, not only by one or two but by scores upon scores; it belongs to the community.”¹

You may wish to take the opportunity with the other members of your group to explore the characteristics of the path of service described above by the House of Justice. You yourself, of course, know this path intimately and recognize the characteristics mentioned. In thinking about them here, try to draw, to the extent possible, on the accumulated experience of the communities with which the members of your group are familiar. To assist you, each of the characteristics is listed below, together with a few ideas which emerged out of the deliberations of several groups, like yours, that carried out this exercise. Reading them should help stimulate discussion in your

group. You can write down in the spaces provided the ideas generated in your consultations, giving specific examples from experience whenever possible.

A path of service invites participation.

- *Focus on service engenders participation. I focused my efforts on service as a tutor of a study circle and assisted its members in carrying out the practices of each course. I could see that, in the process, they became increasingly concerned with the progress of others in the community. Gradually, with every cycle of activity, more and more people with whom they were in touch began to participate in the endeavors of the community. As a result, our local community could contribute significantly to the movement of the entire cluster.*
- *A path of service invites many people, each serving in one form or another the various needs of the global Plans. In the case of the spiritual education of children, for example, one person from a group that has studied Book 3 offers her home as a venue, a few visit families and encourage children to attend, and one or two teach the class. They are all advancing on the same path.*
- *In our cluster, we are developing our ability to invite people to join us on the path of service. This requires generosity, and generosity builds trust. When we visit the parents of the junior youth, for example, we share our thoughts with them freely and they begin to trust us. The support of the parents encourages the junior youth to invite their peers to join the program.*

It beckons to new horizons.

- *As we walk the path of service, the horizon changes and we see new possibilities. For example, the cluster coordinator for the junior youth program asked me to help her identify potential animators. We could only think of two people, but we were not discouraged. We visited one of the two and he connected us with six others. The next day we visited them all, and now after a few months, three of them have already formed junior youth groups and are serving as animators.*
- *The nature of the sequence of courses is such that it constantly beckons us to new horizons. We can't treat the sequence like a factory line, thinking that if we follow instructions, we will produce a good study circle. The courses of the institute are meant to equip us with capabilities that help us read our reality and act accordingly. When we act and reflect on our actions, new possibilities open before us.*

- *We have had children’s classes for some time, but we now need to organize them according to grades. This is a new horizon.*

It demands effort and movement.

- *Our efforts along the path should be sustained if we want to see progress.*
- *Our efforts have to increase in complexity if we are to see movement.*
- *There needs to be an appreciation for the force of inertia. We all struggle against inertia all the time.*
- *We should not expect that everyone would exert the same degree of effort; nor should we compare our efforts with those of others.*
- *Exerting effort to learn helps us move and advance. It impels us to ask new questions, and in trying to answer them, we gain insights into what it is we are learning. As we advance, the nature of the questions changes.*
- *Our efforts should not be driven by guilt. We should not feel we are forced to do something. What motivates us to exert effort on the path of service is our desire to serve Bahá’u’lláh.*

It accommodates different paces and strides.

- *Some are able to run, while others can only take small steps. What is essential is that we advance together as a community, accommodating different paces.*
- *The path is not defined by predetermined steps that should be taken by every single person. If this were the case, we realized, our progress would end up being extremely limited. What was important, we came to understand, was to create an environment*

in which both those eager to move fast and those wishing to take smaller steps were encouraged to act.

- *This characteristic of the path became more noticeable as the number of participants grew.*
- *When I was studying Book 1, the tutor used to call and visit every member of our study circle one by one. None of us were Bahá'ís at the time. We each had our own struggles. It was especially hard for some of us to be consistent in our attendance. But he helped us consider our possibilities and overcome obstacles, so gradually participation became more regular. He would also make sure that those who wanted to form an activity were able to do so quickly so as not to lose the burgeoning enthusiasm to serve.*

It is structured and defined.

- *When the path is not structured, we tend to make arbitrary rules. We take one example and say this is how things are. Or, we try random things hoping that one of them works. But when a path is structured, we work in a learning mode and build on our strength. We apply our approaches in many different spaces to see how they can be adapted and which can become more universally applicable.*
- *The children's class curriculum is structured and defined. The first grade consists of short quotations, memorization, storytelling, coloring, and cooperative games. The structure is simple enough to help anyone who has the inclination and the desire to teach children to begin to do so. Yet, it leaves room for creativity. And the content is profound enough to have lasting influence.*
- *When I think of structure, I see the growing complexity of acts of service, the way we accompany one another, the interrelationship among core activities, the way institutions guide the process, the cycles of growth, the pattern of study, action, reflection and consultation.*

A path can be experienced and known, not only by one or two but by scores upon scores.

- *This is not just my path. It is our path and we walk it together.*
- *In our institute campaigns, we need to envision large cohorts of youth moving through the sequence of courses. There seems to be no limit to the number of those willing to participate. The youth will come and they will bring others. We just need to remember to ask them if they have friends who would also be interested in walking the path of service.*
- *As the number of participants in study circles in our cluster grew, the pace at which groups moved through the books quickened, and the purpose of the sequence of courses became better and better appreciated. Group after group moved into the field of service.*
- *Our Area Teaching Committee has been assisting us to organize ourselves into teams. It helps the teams to read their reality and to become aware of the number of parents, siblings, relatives and friends associated in one way or another with the core activities. As such, we are able to visualize the participation of tens and hundreds of people in a broad diversity of endeavors.*

SECTION 2

After describing the nature of the path of service traced out by the institute courses, the message cited in the previous section continues as follows:

“To walk a path is a concept equally expressive. It requires of the individual volition and choice; it calls for a set of skills and abilities but also elicits certain qualities and attitudes; it necessitates a logical progression but admits, when needed, related lines of exploration; it may seem easy at the outset but becomes more challenging further along. And crucially, one walks the path in the company of others.”²

Another discussion in your group—this time on what it means to walk a path of service—will prove helpful in the explorations we are undertaking in this unit. Unlike the exercise in the previous section, this one will not include full statements made by others who have discussed the above excerpt in similar reflections. However, a few of the insights they gained in their discussions are shared here: in our efforts to walk the path, our volition is strengthened by hope, which springs from reliance on the power of divine assistance; we receive spiritual sustenance from the study of the Word of God and this enables us to fight apathy; we exercise choice in

giving up that which is lower for that which is higher; we strive to attain unto purity of heart and try to avoid possessiveness, competition, paternalism and a sense of superiority. In addition, several others have noted that the progression of institute courses is logical but not rigid; the main sequence of courses is focused on capabilities that individuals and groups need as they advance on the path of service. One person has made the following insightful remark: “In walking the path we align ourselves with the forces of integration and resist the opposing forces of disintegration that sap our energies. No one can do this without the support and encouragement of others.”

In the spaces provided below, you may wish to write down the insights your group gains from your deliberations on what it means to walk a path of service, citing examples from experience:

To walk a path requires of the individual volition and choice.

It calls for a set of skills and abilities but also elicits certain qualities and attitudes.

It necessitates a logical progression but admits, when needed, related lines of exploration.

It may seem easy at the outset but becomes more challenging further along.

One walks the path in the company of others.

The concept of the path will be present in our deliberations throughout this unit. Let us end this section by memorizing the following quotation:

“Wert thou to consider this world, and realize how fleeting are the things that pertain unto it, thou wouldst choose to tread no path except the path of service to the Cause of thy Lord. None would have the power to deter thee from celebrating His praise, though all men should arise to oppose thee.”³

SECTION 3

Having reflected on the path of service that together we tread, we can now explore what it means “to accompany” one another as we walk it. Language allows the verb to be used in a variety of ways: people, for example, accompany each other to the store or on a ride, in their studies or in their travels. But “to accompany” has a very special meaning for us in the context of our service to the Cause. In its Riḍván 2010 message, the Universal House of Justice refers to the progress made by the Bahá’í community worldwide at the level of culture and states the following:

“This evolution in collective consciousness is discernable in the growing frequency with which the word ‘accompany’ appears in conversations among the friends, a word that is being endowed with new meaning as it is integrated into the common vocabulary of the Bahá’í community. It signals the significant strengthening of a culture in which learning is the mode of operation, a mode that fosters the informed

participation of more and more people in a united effort to apply Bahá'u'lláh's teachings to the construction of a divine civilization, which the Guardian states is the primary mission of the Faith. Such an approach offers a striking contrast to the spiritually bankrupt and moribund ways of an old social order that so often seeks to harness human energy through domination, through greed, through guilt or through manipulation.

“In relationships among the friends, then, this development in culture finds expression in the quality of their interactions. Learning as a mode of operation requires that all assume a posture of humility, a condition in which one becomes forgetful of self, placing complete trust in God, reliant on His all-sustaining power and confident in His unfailing assistance, knowing that He, and He alone, can change the gnat into an eagle, the drop into a boundless sea. And in such a state souls labor together ceaselessly, delighting not so much in their own accomplishments but in the progress and services of others. So it is that their thoughts are centered at all times on helping one another scale the heights of service to His Cause and soar in the heaven of His knowledge. This is what we see in the present pattern of activity unfolding across the globe, propagated by young and old, by veteran and newly enrolled, working side by side.”⁴

It is clear from the above passage that the concept “to accompany”, as it relates to our service to the Cause, has far-reaching implications both for the life of the community and the individuals who comprise it. Let us try to gain a few initial insights into these implications by doing the following exercises:

1. To begin, call to mind the many instances in the past when you were accompanied by others in the field of service, say, when conducting classes for children, when contributing to the spiritual empowerment of a group of junior youth, or when acting as the tutor of a study circle. What were some of the attitudes and qualities evinced by those who helped you develop your capacity to serve? Write them in the space provided.

2. In a community where the word “accompany” is finding expression in the quality of the interactions among the friends as described by the Universal House of Justice, which of the following—each legitimate in its own sphere—would characterize the relationship between two individuals, one of whom is assisting the other in carrying out an act of service?

_____ An expert to a novice

_____ A teacher to a student

- _____ A manager to an employee
 - _____ A parent to a child
 - _____ A trainer to a trainee
 - _____ A skillful master to an apprentice
 - _____ A knowledgeable person to the uninformed
 - _____ Two friends, one more experienced than the other in a specific area of action, learning together
3. As we accompany one another on a path of service, energy is released through interactions characterized by humility, selflessness, reliance on God, and the genuine desire to see others progress. In dedicating ourselves to the construction of a new civilization, we should be conscious of the “spiritually bankrupt and moribund ways” of a disintegrating world and make sure that such ways do not tarnish the quality of our interactions. In this connection, give examples of occasions when, in the present social order, energy is harnessed through:
- Domination
 - Greed
 - Guilt
 - Manipulation
4. Whatever the examples cited by your group in the previous exercise, you need to remember that those who use such means in order to further their own interests and ideologies do so in subtle ways. In this respect, you may find it helpful to reflect on the following questions:
- a. Is it possible to mask domination by acts of loving kindness?
 - b. Is it possible to manipulate people by pretending to give them factual knowledge and information?
 - c. Is it possible to hide greed by acts of generosity?
 - d. Is it possible to give legitimacy to guilt by evoking obedience to God?

It is important to mention here that the purpose of the last two exercises was merely to make us aware of tendencies in the world we need to avoid. Most acts of kindness we witness in our lives are sincere. People share knowledge without any desire to manipulate. Generosity is a spiritual quality that adorns the souls of many human beings. And obedience to God is often discussed without stirring feelings of guilt. We each should take care, lest we fall into the habit of doubting the motives of those with whom we interact. Suspicion is a dangerous trait that can crush the will to act. Our ways of accompanying one another on the path of service should be free of suspicion.

SECTION 4

The passage written by the Universal House of Justice studied in the previous section suggests that the capability of accompanying a friend on the path of service is inseparable from a disposition centered on learning. We can examine this disposition at two levels, individual and collective.

1. At the level of the individual, the House of Justice mentions that “learning as a mode of operation” requires that we “all assume a posture of humility”. Decide which of the following statements represent the kind of thoughts occupying the mind of a person who has adopted the requisite posture:

_____ If only they would listen to me, we would get results much faster.

_____ They do not understand; I will just go ahead and do things my own way.

_____ She is capable but still young. There is nothing I can learn from her.

_____ I should listen carefully to what others have to say; there is always something to learn.

_____ Perhaps this approach is better than the one I had in mind; after all, there could be a number of approaches that would work well in this situation.

_____ I tried implementing this idea before and it did not work. Nobody else should try it.

_____ I tried implementing this idea before and it did not work. But there is no need to mention this to anyone; let everyone learn from experience.

_____ I tried implementing this idea before and it did not work. Perhaps I can talk about my experience and see if it helps us find a fruitful approach.

You may wish to add a few other thoughts to the above list, both those that might occupy the mind of a person in a learning mode and those that would not. Here is some space for you to note them down.

2. The Universal House of Justice indicates in the passage that, as the concept “to accompany” has taken root in the community and been incorporated into our thinking, a culture has been greatly strengthened in which “learning is the mode of operation”. At the

collective level, then, the posture of learning must manifest itself in certain characteristics that distinguish the culture of the community. Decide which of the following statements reflect the culture of a community in which learning about how to participate in building a divine civilization can take place:

- _____ Continuous, consistent and focused effort within every area of activity is universally valued, and freneticism is avoided.
- _____ The accumulated knowledge gained by various groups, each working systematically in a specific area of endeavor, is respected and the community continuously draws on their growing experience.
- _____ In the arena of action, pitting one approach against another is prevalent.
- _____ In the name of evaluation, every experience is minutely dissected and criticized.
- _____ The short-lived excitement and momentary disappointment that stem from narrowly defined notions of “success” and “failure” are generally avoided.
- _____ The expectation that every activity is to be carried out in an idealized state of perfection is allowed to hamper universal participation.
- _____ Long-term commitment to action is the norm.
- _____ The salutary and combined effect of diverse acts of service carried out within a common, overarching framework by a growing number of individuals and groups is prized.
- _____ Discussions among individuals, groups and institutions are driven by the desire to explore, to gain fresh insights, and to advance.

As with the previous exercise, you may wish to add a few other statements to the above list. Some space is provided here for you to do so.

SECTION 5

Before we continue with our explorations into the two related concepts that are the focus of this unit, we should pause and consider the context in which all of our endeavors are undertaken: the creation of the nucleus of that glorious civilization envisioned in the Writings of

Bahá'u'lláh. We know that the three protagonists in this enterprise are the individual, the institutions, and the community and that a new set of relationships is being forged among them. When viewed in light of the attributes that are to distinguish these relationships, the concepts we are considering here, particularly the concept “to accompany”, take on even greater significance. The following passage from a message dated 28 December 2010 addressed by the Universal House of Justice to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors offers us valuable insight in this regard:

“To understand the nature of the interacting processes that, in their totality, engender the expansion and consolidation of the Faith is vital to the successful execution of the Plan. In your efforts to further such understanding, you and your auxiliaries are encouraged to bear in mind a concept that lies at the foundation of the current global enterprise and, indeed, at the very heart of every stage of the Divine Plan, namely, that progress is achieved through the development of three participants—the individual, the institutions, and the community. Throughout human history, interactions among these three have been fraught with difficulties at every turn, with the individual clamoring for freedom, the institution demanding submission, and the community claiming precedence. Every society has defined, in one way or another, the relationships that bind the three, giving rise to periods of stability, interwoven with turmoil. Today, in this age of transition, as humanity struggles to attain its collective maturity, such relationships—nay, the very conception of the individual, of social institutions, and of the community—continue to be assailed by crises too numerous to count. The worldwide crisis of authority provides proof enough. So grievous have been its abuses, and so deep the suspicion and resentment it now arouses, that the world is becoming increasingly ungovernable—a situation made all the more perilous by the weakening of community ties.

“Every follower of Bahá'u'lláh knows well that the purpose of His Revelation is to bring into being a new creation. No sooner had ‘the First Call gone forth from His lips than the whole creation was revolutionized, and all that are in the heavens and all that are on earth were stirred to the depths.’ The individual, the institutions, and the community—the three protagonists in the Divine Plan—are being shaped under the direct influence of His Revelation, and a new conception of each, appropriate for a humanity that has come of age, is emerging. The relationships that bind them, too, are undergoing a profound transformation, bringing into the realm of existence civilization-building powers which can only be released through conformity with His decree. At a fundamental level these relationships are characterized by cooperation and reciprocity, manifestations of the interconnectedness that governs the universe.”⁵

The passage continues by describing some of the characteristics of the individual, the institutions, and the community that will emerge as the civilization-building process inspired by Bahá'u'lláh's Revelation advances. What may prove useful at this point is for you to form an image in your mind of a world in which cooperation and reciprocity characterize relations among the three protagonists under consideration here. The following thoughts may help you in your reflections, and you may wish to add to the list other ideas generated through consultations with friends.

- A world in which everyone takes delight in others’ accomplishments, in which jealousy and competitiveness find no room
- A world in which people can detach themselves from their own opinions and are willing to learn with others
- A world in which the material and spiritual progress of the individual and the advancement of the community are harmonized
- A world in which there is faith in the capacity of every individual
- A world in which actions arise from a longing to please God and to obey His teachings, and not out of a desire for status or power
- A world in which institutions foster and channel individual initiative, and individuals show discipline in not following the promptings of their own egos
- A world in which members of institutions have no desire for personal gain and, with self-abnegation, dedicate their energies to the empowerment of the people they serve
- A world in which members of institutions governing society exemplify meekness and humility
- A world in which those called upon to serve on institutions work shoulder to shoulder with members of the community
- A world in which institutions are sources of guidance and in which wholehearted obedience to them is recognized as a necessary condition for the progress of the three protagonists
- A world in which the community provides conditions that allow the talents and capacities of its members to find collective expression
- A world in which the community is free from a “generation gap”, permitting the energy of its younger members and the experience of its older members to be harnessed
- A world in which women and men work shoulder to shoulder in every aspect of community life
- A world in which the economic status of individuals and families has no bearing on their participation in the life of the community
- A world in which knowledge is shared freely and is dedicated to the advancement of a global civilization prosperous in its material and spiritual dimensions

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Once you have added other statements to the list, discuss in your group the following three questions:

- a. Is the world you are imagining a utopian dream, or will it actually come into being?
- b. How distant is the world described by the sentiments above from the world we see around us today?
- c. What will be required of the growing but still relatively small number of people who are dedicating themselves to the service of the Cause and are striving to close the distance that separates our world from that which Bahá'u'lláh envisions?

SECTION 6

Our discussions over the past few sections have helped us explore, if only briefly, the expanded meaning of the word “accompany” as it pertains to treading a path of service. Let us consider a story that offers insights into the qualities, attitudes, and skills we need to develop as we try to serve the Cause in a learning mode and assist others in their efforts to do the same. The story, the first episode of which we present in this section, is put together from observations of real situations and, therefore, represents the experience of numerous friends as they strive to translate ideals into reality.

Monica is a nineteen-year-old youth from a small town who is starting her first year of tertiary education at a nearby university. She also has a part-time job to help with the expenses of her family. For the past two years, she has been serving as an animator for a group of eleven youngsters—a responsibility she holds dear to her heart. Having seen the effects of the program on herself and her friends, she cherishes every moment she finds to assist the group with its study, with service projects, and with the other activities that it energetically pursues. Whenever she thinks of the progress that the individual members are making, she is filled with a deep sense of joy and is humbled by the opportunity of playing a part in the process of their spiritual and intellectual empowerment. Her own connection to the junior youth spiritual empowerment program dates back some seven years, when she herself was a participant in a group in her neighborhood. The many

conversations she had with her peers on spiritual themes drawn from the texts they studied, and the service projects they carried out together, had a profound effect on her during those formative years; they awakened within her a desire to help others in their spiritual progress.

Today Monica has taken on a new responsibility. During a reflection gathering of animators, the cluster coordinator of the junior youth program, Andres, announced that a number of youth who had just completed the study of Book 5 were eager to start serving as animators. Since one of them, Rodrigo, lives relatively close to Monica, she was asked whether she could accompany him in his endeavor to form a group and help its members begin the activities required by the junior youth spiritual empowerment program. Although not fully confident in her ability to do justice to the task, Monica has decided to put her trust in God and to do her best to accompany Rodrigo on his path of service. She actually remembers him from the gathering held some months ago, when he and his friends were first invited to participate in community-building efforts in the cluster.

During their initial discussion Monica finds out that Rodrigo knows some junior youth in his neighborhood, whom he occasionally meets in the park. He mentions that, while studying Book 5, he thought about them and wondered how he could describe the program in a way that would attract their attention. Monica encourages Rodrigo to pursue this idea and offers to go with him to meet the junior youth. On the day the meeting is to take place, Monica and Rodrigo get together to discuss what they could say to the group. They refer to relevant sections of Book 5 and remind themselves of the great potentialities of junior youth and the aims of the program as described in that book. They say a few prayers together and walk to the neighborhood park where the youngsters are playing football.

After the game, Rodrigo introduces Monica to a group of some eight youngsters, and they begin to chat. Soon, Rodrigo, with a face beaming with joy, mentions to them that he has recently learned about a program the aim of which is to release the powers of young people their age. The junior youth listen attentively, but one of them quietly walks away. Rodrigo talks about the concept of a junior youth group in pursuit of excellence, the kind of themes the members discuss, and the type of activities they carry out together. At some point, Monica feels that the ideas being presented may seem a little abstract, and so when there is a pause, she tells them about the group with which she is working—how it was formed, how often it meets, the material its members study together. She also describes some of the service projects the group has carried out. She ends by talking about the strong bonds of friendship that have been forged among them all and what a joy it is for everyone to study, to learn, and to serve together.

The example helps Rodrigo's young friends understand the nature of the program, and he feels it is time to ask them if they would like to form a group. He begins to talk but loses the thread of his thoughts and is not sure how to continue the conversation. He looks towards Monica for help. She comes to his rescue in a most natural way. She describes briefly how important the first meeting of her group was in giving it shape and purpose. What follows is straightforward. There is a short discussion about the best time to meet. Rodrigo and Monica basically keep quiet. Agreement is soon reached: One of the junior youth offers his home for the first meeting. They agree to see each other the next day at 3:00 in the afternoon in the park and walk to his home. Some express the hope of

bringing one or two of their friends who they think would also be interested in the program.

Walking back from the park, Monica and Rodrigo reflect on the experience. Things could not have gone better. Monica comments on how well Rodrigo introduced the program and how the junior youth were drawn to it by the sincerity of his comments. Without overanalyzing, they discuss how they could have explained a couple of the ideas more clearly. Rodrigo asks Monica to join him for the first meeting and she accepts. They decide to review separately that evening the section of Book 5 in which the nature of the initial meetings of a junior youth group is explored.

1. Circle the words which you feel characterized Monica’s attitude:

Kind	Open
Criticizing	Forced
Encouraging	Overbearing
Patronizing	Natural

2. In what way did Monica help enhance Rodrigo’s confidence in his capacity to serve as an animator?

3. How different would the outcome of the visit have been if Monica had any of the following thoughts?

- a. Aren’t I good! I can see that I am really helping him.
- b. Look at him. He really doesn’t know what he is doing. Good thing I came along.
- c. I’m just going to pray silently and let him be guided by spiritual forces.
- d. At this stage, all he really needs to do is to follow my instructions.
- e. I should make sure I correct any mistakes now, or he will learn the wrong way.

4. And how different might the outcome have been if Rodrigo had thought about Monica’s assistance in any one of the following ways?

- a. I am self-sufficient. I don’t need anyone’s help.
- b. Those who offer to help me think they are better than me.

- c. Anyone who offers to accompany me wants to evaluate how I am doing.
 - d. I don't want anyone to accompany me when I am carrying out an act of service; it is sufficient that I share my experience in meetings of reflection.
 - e. No one offers help without wanting some favor in return.
 - f. I don't want to be taught by others how to serve.
 - g. I don't want to be judged by others.
5. How important was the discussion that took place between Monica and Rodrigo before they went to meet the junior youth? How effective would they have been if they had gone to the park without any preparation? Discuss in your group the disadvantages of both the lack of preparation and over-preparation in such circumstances.

6. There are, of course, numerous circumstances that lead to the formation of a junior youth group. Discuss with your friends how you would go about helping an animator who is establishing a group for the first time to do so in each of the following contexts:
- a. In a neighborhood where the animator knows some junior youth and their families
 - b. In a neighborhood where the animator is not yet familiar with members of the community
 - c. Among the young members of the animator's extended family or close friends
 - d. In a school where those administering it have little knowledge of the junior youth program

7. Your concern as you study this unit is not limited to what it means to accompany an animator of a junior youth group. You may find it fruitful, then, to repeat the preceding exercise, now in relation to helping someone who wishes to start a study circle and another who intends to begin a class for children. The contexts you choose, of course, need not be any of those mentioned above; your group may come up with others more appropriate to the task at hand. In the case of study circles, a significant context is one in which a group has completed the junior youth spiritual empowerment program and is ready to begin the main sequence of the institute courses.

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and extend across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

SECTION 7

In this section we will examine more closely the nature of the relationship between two individuals such as Monica and Rodrigo who are walking together on a path of service. You would agree that what distinguishes the interactions of those who serve the Cause together is true friendship—this, regardless of age, experience, or background. True friendship is an ideal which many yearn for but find difficult to attain. When we seek to gain insight into a human attribute, we do well to direct our inner sight towards the infinite Divine Source. In the case of friendship, we learn many a lesson about its nature from our true Friend.

Reflect on the following excerpt from *The Hidden Words*:

“Worldly friends, seeking their own good, appear to love one the other, whereas the true Friend hath loved and doth love you for your own sakes; indeed He hath suffered for your guidance countless afflictions.”⁶

The Manifestation of God, our true Friend, loves us for our own sake. We, too, love our friends for their own sake and not for the good that could come our way. While the principle is clear, it is difficult to put it into practice whenever, inadvertently, we apply worldly standards to

our relationships. What do we see when we look around us? We see friendship becoming a commodity that is negotiated, implicitly or explicitly, its value being increasingly measured by how one or more people benefit from it. And so often, momentary emotions impel people to become friends, and later, the same emotions force them apart. Read and reflect on the following quotation:

“The love which exists between the hearts of believers is prompted by the ideal of the unity of spirits. This love is attained through the knowledge of God, so that men see the Divine Love reflected in the heart. Each sees in the other the Beauty of God reflected in the soul, and finding this point of similarity, they are attracted to one another in love. This love will make all men the waves of one sea, this love will make them all the stars of one heaven and the fruits of one tree. This love will bring the realization of true accord, the foundation of real unity.

“But the love which sometimes exists between friends is not (true) love, because it is subject to transmutation; this is merely fascination. As the breeze blows, the slender trees yield. If the wind is in the East the tree leans to the West, and if the wind turns to the West the tree leans to the East. This kind of love is originated by the accidental conditions of life. This is not love, it is merely acquaintanceship; it is subject to change.

“Today you will see two souls apparently in close friendship; tomorrow all this may be changed. Yesterday they were ready to die for one another, today they shun one another’s society! This is not love; it is the yielding of the hearts to the accidents of life. When that which has caused this ‘love’ to exist passes, the love passes also; this is not in reality love.”⁷

The idea being advanced here is that the arena of service is a significant space, although not the only one, in which the kind of friendship extolled in passages like the above can be forged. Let us reflect on this proposition. People whose aims and ideals converge are naturally drawn to each other. The sincere desire to serve humanity is a force that brings people together and allows them to form bonds of friendship. But how strong and enduring are such bonds? In general, one can think of various ties that keep individuals friends. Decide which of the following, although legitimate, is the weakest and which the strongest—in other words, which is most likely to endure through tests and difficulties:

- ___ Common personal interests
- ___ Common interest in the context of family
- ___ Common interest based on political ideology
- ___ Common interest based on ethnicity
- ___ Common interest based on nationality
- ___ Common purpose to construct a new society
- ___ Love of God and knowledge of His purpose

Although in the context of service relationships acquire depth, we should be careful, lest, in the name of service, we place excessive demands on friendship and cause estrangement. What

motivates us to serve is the love of God and what gives direction to our efforts is knowledge of His purpose for humanity. An ever-increasing understanding of this reality helps us to avoid unnecessary tension between our yearning to see progress in an area of service, on the one hand, and our desire to create lasting bonds of friendship, on the other. These tensions can arise, for example, when we perceive the requirements of service and those of true friendship as distinct and separate. Think about the act of service one can undertake as a tutor of a study circle or as an animator. Being a true friend to the participants of a study circle or to the members of a junior youth group implies that one has to acquire attributes required by selfless service to the Cause. And selfless service to the Cause requires true love for those we wish to serve. These two requirements are not to be separated from each other. Describe how the following factors, although external to the reality of service, test the friendship between someone who is acting as a tutor and the participants of a study circle or between one who is serving as an animator and the members of a junior youth group:

- a. Undue expectations: _____

- b. Impatience with the pace at which participants advance in their study: _____

- c. Lack of attention to the difficult circumstances of one or another participant: _____

- d. Attachment to fixed and predetermined procedures and outcomes: _____

SECTION 8

Keeping in mind the above thoughts on the relation between friendship and service, we can consider the nature of the interactions between those who, in whatever capacity, are helping one another to advance. Let us examine first the example of Rodrigo as he tries to form a junior youth group. He no doubt wishes to become a true friend to each member of the group. He is also motivated to serve as an animator in order to contribute to the progress of his community. But once he becomes engaged in this area of service, he needs to ensure that the urgency he feels to contribute to the transformation of society does not cause him to expect quick results, thus

endangering the friendships he is trying to cultivate. At the same time, he needs to exercise care, lest, in the interest of preserving friendship, he comes to neglect the spiritual standards that should guide the members of the group. Reflecting on the following situations in your group will help clarify this idea.

- a. The manner in which Rodrigo interacts with the junior youth during the first few meetings assists them to see the purpose of the program and helps set the proper limits within which they are to interact with each other and with Rodrigo. Which of the following do you think best illustrates what Rodrigo needs to do in the first few meetings?

_____ Set strict rules that each member of the group should follow.

_____ Guide a discussion among the junior youth about the concept of excellence and how in their meetings they can strive for it.

_____ Give the impression that, because he is their friend, they are free to act in whatever way they like when he is with them.

- b. Several junior youth do not regularly attend the group meetings. Which of the responses below demonstrates that Rodrigo still loves them and is their friend?

_____ He treats them with impatience thinking that they are wasting his time.

_____ He ignores their absences, pretending everything is fine each time they are present.

_____ He visits their families in order to discover the causes of their infrequent attendance by learning more about the environment in which they live and the challenges they face.

- c. Despite the advance made by the members of the group, there are setbacks, particularly in the way they sometimes behave. Which of the following reactions indicates that Rodrigo is aware of the profound value of both the service he is rendering and the friendship he is forming with the junior youth?

_____ He feels despondent each time there is a serious setback and contemplates abandoning the group.

_____ He decides he is fulfilling his duty by offering the program to the junior youth and that he is not responsible for the way they respond to it.

_____ He knows that the social environment can often exert a negative influence on the junior youth. He is, however, certain that the understanding they progressively acquire of spiritual concepts and the profound joy they experience in the service projects they undertake in the community will change their lives for the better.

Now let us turn to Monica and Rodrigo and reflect on the nature of a friendship such as theirs. One can imagine that Monica wishes the well-being and the progress of her friend. She is also aware that Rodrigo's capacity as an animator is developed in practice. She sees no contradiction between being a friend to Rodrigo and accompanying him as he walks the path of service. However, mistaken notions of what friendship and service each demand can create a duality that is harmful to both. Try to write an alternative to each of the following thoughts that could come to Monica's mind, which imply in some way that there is a dichotomy between friendship and service to the Cause:

- a. I should get to know everything about Rodrigo if I am to help him serve as an animator.

- b. Rodrigo and I should regularly go out with other youth and do fun things. It is not enough just to serve together.

- c. Our friendship ends if Rodrigo abandons his service as an animator.

- d. I can accompany Rodrigo only if he continues to serve unaffected by any challenges he may face in his life.

- e. Our friendship will suffer if I offer Rodrigo advice regarding his service as an animator; it is best just to praise him.

-
-
-
-
- f. We are friends and I can tell Rodrigo anything that comes to my mind about him and the way he serves.
-
-
-
-

To the extent that the interactions between Monica and Rodrigo are imbued with the kind of love described the passage below, their growing friendship, as they walk a path of service to the Cause together, will bring forth the most excellent fruits. You may wish to memorize the passage, if you have not already done so on an earlier occasion:

“The divine friends must be attracted to and enamored of each other and ever be ready and willing to sacrifice their own lives for each other. Should one soul from amongst the believers meet another, it must be as though a thirsty one with parched lips has reached to the fountain of the water of life, or a lover has met his true beloved. For one of the greatest divine wisdoms regarding the appearance of the holy Manifestations is this: The souls may come to know each other and become intimate with each other; the power of the love of God may make all of them the waves of one sea, the flowers of one rose garden, and the stars of one heaven. This is the wisdom for the appearance of the holy Manifestations! When the most great bestowal reveals itself in the hearts of the believers, the world of nature will be transformed, the darkness of the contingent being will vanish, and heavenly illumination will be obtained. Then the whole world will become the Paradise of Abhá, every one of the believers of God will become a blessed tree, producing wonderful fruits.”⁸

SECTION 9

In order to continue gaining insights into the many subtleties involved in accompanying a friend on a path of service, let us resume our story of Rodrigo and Monica.

The next afternoon, Monica and Rodrigo arrive in the park a few minutes before 3:00 p.m. and see that two of the junior youth, Paola and Roxana, are already there. They greet them and ask about the others. Paola explains that Sergio, in whose home they were to meet, had to run errands for his mother and that she is not sure what the rest are doing. Rodrigo, who expected to meet most of his young friends, feels discouraged and does not know what to say. Monica, on the other hand, remembers from her past experience that events often don't unfold as one hopes and shows delight in seeing Paola and Roxana.

“We came because we were curious to see if you and Rodrigo would turn up,” says Paola. “What should we do now?” asks Roxana. Rodrigo’s disappointment vanishes rapidly as he sees the enthusiasm of the two junior youth and Monica’s joyful interaction with them. In the conversation that ensues the four friends get to know one another better. Rodrigo and Monica learn that the young girls, whose homes are next door to one another, have already told their parents about their previous meeting in the park and that, in fact, Paola’s mother knows Rodrigo’s family. She is a teacher at the primary school where his younger brother studies. Monica seizes the moment and suggests that they go to visit Paola’s parents. The girls agree. Upon their arrival, Paola’s mother, Mrs. Ramirez, warmly welcomes them. She listens attentively to Rodrigo as he tells her about the recent training course in which he participated. She is particularly interested to hear Rodrigo’s explanation about the role older youth can play in releasing the potential of junior youth. When it comes to describing the junior youth spiritual empowerment program in which they hope Paola and Roxana can participate, Rodrigo asks Monica to speak. Monica describes the group that she is serving and how it was formed, the purpose of the program and the activities the junior youth carry out, and how she has seen their spiritual and intellectual powers develop. Mrs. Ramirez is impressed by Monica’s wealth of experience and by her constancy in nurturing a group of youngsters for over two years. She comes to trust these two young people whose sincerity and high sense of purpose she finds exemplary. She offers to help them if they face any challenges in establishing the program, which, she thinks, is needed in her neighborhood.

Monica and Rodrigo are encouraged by their conversation with Mrs. Ramirez. Over the next week, which coincides with the expansion phase of the current cycle of activity in the cluster, they meet with many junior youth, sometimes with the help of Paola and Roxana and sometimes on their own. They also visit systematically most of their families, drawing on the assistance of a few older members of the community who are participating in the activities of the expansion phase. Rodrigo learns that bringing some ten to twelve junior youth together and helping them form a group takes a great deal of effort. Initially, one has to talk to quite a few. Many will express interest in the program, but not all of them will enter it. From those who do, some will only participate in a couple of meetings. But if one perseveres with eagerness and joy, before long, a solid and stable group is formed. Monica assures Rodrigo that regular attendance in the meetings of the group is a habit that the junior youth will gradually acquire. With the help of Paola and Roxana, who remain enthusiastic, they soon find several interested junior youth. As days go by, Rodrigo becomes more and more adept at responding wisely to different situations. Not all parents are as welcoming and encouraging as Mrs. Ramirez. While everyone is polite, a few do not seem interested or lack the time to engage in a conversation on themes related to the spiritual empowerment of junior youth. On one occasion Monica helps Rodrigo answer with conviction and clarity questions regarding the Faith from the father of a junior youth who has misgivings about the connection of the program to a religion with which he is not familiar. Later the two of them reflect on that specific visit and discuss how Bahá’í-inspired educational materials help widen the scope of conversation with parents, school administrators, teachers, and other members of the community.

So intensive has been the pattern of activity during this period that Rodrigo feels as if they have worked for months. But in fact, only ten days after the initial encounter in the park, there are already eight junior youth who are eagerly awaiting their first meeting.

And among themselves they have set the goal of soon becoming twelve. The assistance rendered by Mrs. Ramirez, particularly her long conversation with Sergio's mother, in whose house the group is to meet, has been crucial to this accomplishment.

1. We need to encourage our friends as we tread the path of service, especially when they encounter difficulties. Say a few words about the way Monica encouraged Rodrigo in the above story with both words and deeds.

2. Encouragement is effective when one is open to receive it. Rodrigo, for example, was able to put aside his disappointment quickly and contribute to a joyful conversation with Paola and Roxana. What attitudes are necessary if we are to transcend the disappointments we will inevitably face on the path of service?

3. Can you make explicit how, in the above story, going beyond specific occurrences and focusing on spiritual reality and potential brought about joy and motivation to serve?

4. The story we have recounted is about the formation of a junior youth group, but it does not represent the only way such a group can be formed. In the diversity of circumstances that exist in the world, there must also be various approaches to the establishment of a class for the spiritual education of children and to the creation of a study circle. In Section 6, you carried out some exercises in which you explored how you would assist an individual who wished to establish one of these three activities in different situations. As our story has unfolded, it has become clear that, beyond the initial steps taken to meet people, a great deal of effort is required to consolidate any one of the three activities.

Your own experience, no doubt, confirms this. You may find it helpful, then, to discuss in your group the various experiences with which you are familiar in establishing the following activities on a solid foundation:

a. A children's class: _____

b. A junior youth group: _____

c. A study circle: _____

5. In the story, Monica and Rodrigo talk about Bahá'í-inspired educational materials. Discuss in your group what this concept means to you. How does an adequate understanding of it help us in widening the scope of our conversation with parents, school administrators, teachers, and other members of the community?

SECTION 10

Through the agency of the training institute, which provides materials, ideas, accounts of experience, and the requisite human resources, growing capacity is created to respond to the desire of more and more people in villages, towns, and neighborhoods of cities throughout the world to partake in a process of spiritual education. Individuals and groups, of course, come into

the educational process promoted by the institute at different stages of life. Some enter in childhood, while others, like Paola and Roxana in our story, are introduced to the process in early adolescence. Still others, attracted by Bahá'u'lláh's vision of a future society and by the opportunity to serve humankind, join as youth and adults.

We all acknowledge the truth that education is most effective when it begins in childhood, nay in infancy, and continues into adulthood. This is an ideal that the Bahá'í community will certainly achieve for sizable populations in the future. At this juncture, however, given the community's current stage of development, the possibility of engaging in the entire educational process, from childhood on, is open to only a relatively small number. For a long time to come, we will have to focus our efforts on all three points of entry—childhood, early adolescence, and youth and adulthood. To take full advantage of the system of education being developed in locality after locality, we should be able to think of these three points of entry and the corresponding activities in two complementary ways: sometimes in terms of one educational process and sometimes in terms of three distinct but interrelated processes.

As a first exercise, discuss in your group how the following statements help us envision the three activities—children's classes, junior youth groups, and study circles—as one educational process:

- a. At the heart of the process is the study of the Word of God.

- b. Emphasis on understanding spiritual concepts serves to tap the roots of motivation in the participants.

- c. Underlying every stage of the educational process are the same assumptions about the nature of the human being and the progress of society.

You may wish to write a few additional statements in the space provided below and explore their implications.

- d. _____

- e. _____

- f. _____

The above exercise points to some of the practical advantages of conceiving the efforts of the training institute in terms of one educational process. The single framework of thought and action guards it against fragmentation. The three educational activities are not seen as competing with one another; it becomes possible to employ and expand the resources of the community in the most effective way. Now let us turn to the complementary view of the three activities as distinct but interrelated processes—what the Universal House of Justice has called “three educational imperatives”. Below are some questions in this regard. You may wish to discuss them in your group as a second exercise here.

- a. What are some of the distinct contributions made to our community-building endeavors by each process—the spiritual education of children, the spiritual empowerment of junior youth, and the development of human resources through study circles and intensive campaigns?
- _____

- b. While all the human resources of the community—youth from different backgrounds and with varied experiences, young mothers, older members, to name a few—can contribute to the advancement of the three educational processes, each component of the population tends to serve the aims of a given process in a special way. Can you give examples of such distinct contributions?

- c. What kind of factors can help the institutions and agencies serving in a cluster determine how much emphasis should be placed, at different stages of its development, on one point of entry or another? In particular, given the special nature of early adolescence in the life of an individual and the extraordinary receptivity found in most populations to the junior youth spiritual empowerment program—even in schools, which are showing growing interest in its Bahá'í-inspired component—what strategies would make it possible for the potential of this activity to be realized?

- d. What are some of the concepts that need to be discussed in visits to families of

– children? _____

– junior youth? _____

– youth who wish to study the main sequence and prepare themselves for acts of service? _____

- e. Why is it important to have separate meetings of reflection for tutors, for animators, and for teachers of children's classes?

You may wish to identify a few similar questions about this second way of looking at the work of the training institute and explore them.

f.

g.

h.

This second exercise shows some of the merits of viewing the efforts of the training institute in terms of three distinct but interrelated processes. Here one sees the particular contributions each makes to the community-building endeavors under way everywhere. Each process receives proper attention according to the realities of a given population as the expansion and consolidation of the Faith advances. Thus, for example, the fact that capacity is being built in more and more individuals to serve as effective teachers of children is appreciated in its own right. So, too, while learning about arrangements that make it possible for youngsters reaching the age of eleven or twelve to pass from the program for the spiritual education of children to the junior youth spiritual empowerment program is given importance, the success of the former is not measured simply in terms of the number of those who continue into the latter. Similarly, the desire to connect the two programs does not obscure the reality that thousands upon thousands of junior youth are already eager to enter an educational process that will change their lives and enable them to contribute meaningfully to the transformation of society. And as far as the study of the main sequence is concerned, the paramount value of an ever-increasing number of people—who identify themselves with Bahá'u'lláh's vision for humanity—walking the path of service together is never forgotten; it is understood that enrollment in the Faith could occur at any point on the path and should not be considered a condition for walking it.

SECTION 11

In its message dated 9 January 2001 to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, the Universal House of Justice states:

“Training alone, of course, does not necessarily lead to an upsurge in teaching activity. In every avenue of service, the friends need sustained encouragement.”⁹

As they advance on a path of service, friends encourage each other through both words and deeds. Encouraging words, of course, are not the same as empty praise, which, in the long run, becomes tiring and leads to disillusionment. Nor can encouraging deeds be reduced to “a pat on the back” or the occasional gift. To be able to encourage those around us and contribute to a nurturing environment, we must be cognizant of the sources from which spiritual energy and drive emanate. We need to ask ourselves: What are the forces that spur us on to greater and greater exertion in the field of service, and how is the spirit with which we labor in the face of difficulties regenerated? The passages quoted below, a few of which are already familiar to you from your study of earlier courses, offer insight into the spiritual roots of encouragement. After reflecting on them with the members of your group, write in the space provided at the end of the section some of your thoughts in this connection.

‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us that it is through the rays of the Sun of Truth that we develop and are educated and encouraged:

“The sun is the life-giver to the physical bodies of all creatures upon earth; without its warmth their growth would be stunted, their development would be arrested, they would decay and die. Even so do the souls of men need the Sun of Truth to shed its rays upon their souls, to develop them, to educate and encourage them. As the sun is to the body of a man so is the Sun of Truth to his soul.”¹⁰

The Sun of Truth is ever present and its rays always shining. Awareness of this reality does not allow gloom and despair to settle in our hearts. We should never forget that God’s bounties are continually showered upon us, and we must be ever ready to receive them as we walk the path of service. The sense of hope that we derive from such knowledge reinvigorates our souls and galvanizes us into action. Thus does ‘Abdu’l-Bahá encourage us to pray:

“In the darksome night of despair, my eye turneth expectant and full of hope to the morn of Thy boundless favor and at the hour of dawn my drooping soul is refreshed and strengthened in remembrance of Thy beauty and perfection.”¹¹

Together with an abiding sense of hope, our faith in a bright future and the spirit of optimism that it evokes are powerful sources of energy as we strive to serve the Cause:

“Lift up your hearts above the present and look with eyes of faith into the future! Today the seed is sown, the grain falls upon the earth, but behold the day will come when it shall rise a glorious tree and the branches thereof shall be laden with fruit. Rejoice and be glad that this day has dawned, try to realize its power, for it is indeed wonderful!”¹²

“The bright day is coming. The nucleus of the new race is forming. The harbinger of the new ideals of international justice is appearing. The trees of hope will become verdant; the copper of scorn and derision will be transmuted into the gold of honor and praise; the arid desert of ignorance will be transformed into the luxuriant garden of knowledge; the threatening clouds shall be dispelled and the stars of faith and charity will again twinkle in the clear heaven of consciousness.”¹³

“... as material affairs go from bad to worse in the world, the confidence, optimism, love and hope of the believers will, by force of contrast, shine out as an ever brighter beacon, leading the people to the Path of Truth, the way laid down by God, which alone can guide them to the promise of the future.”¹⁴

To maintain a spirit of optimism, we must appreciate the dynamic interplay of crisis and victory in the onward march of the Faith:

“Let it ever be borne in mind that we earn our victories through test and trial; we turn crisis to the advantage of progress by seizing the opportunity it provides to demonstrate the viability and winning power of our principles. In the onward surge of the Cause of God, crisis and victory have always alternated and have ever proven to be the staple of progress.”¹⁵

And a vision of the greatness of this Day, and the powers inherent in it, will sustain us even in the face of the most formidable obstacles, for we know that accomplishments unimaginable before are, through the aid of the hosts of the Celestial Concourse, now made possible:

“This Day a door is open wider than both heaven and earth. The eye of the mercy of Him Who is the Desire of the worlds is turned towards all men. An act, however infinitesimal, is, when viewed in the mirror of the knowledge of God, mightier than a mountain. Every drop proffered in His path is as the sea in that mirror. For this is the Day which the one true God, glorified be He, hath announced in all His Books, unto His Prophets and His Messengers.”¹⁶

In the space below, you may now wish to write some of your thoughts about the spiritual resources upon which we draw in the field of service.

SECTION 12

Passages such as the ones quoted above help us gain a deeper understanding of the spiritual resources upon which we all can draw in generating and sustaining enthusiasm for service to the Cause. Having reflected on these passages, we can now enter into a discussion on how friends encourage each other as they walk a path of service together. Listed below are some of the habits and patterns of conduct that might distinguish their interactions. For each, think of different situations you have encountered and briefly describe one or two that you would consider instances of encouragement. Try to think especially of situations in which one friend with more experience is working alongside another. As an assistance to you, examples for the first two below, based on the experience of friends serving in different clusters, are provided.

- a. Noticing the smallest progress a friend has made in an act of service and speaking of it in a natural way within a larger context

When visiting a class a friend was teaching, a coordinator in a cluster noticed that the children recited prayers with ease and enthusiasm. Remembering that the teacher had initially been concerned about the difficulties the children faced in this regard, she pointed out this seemingly small progress to her friend. They went on to talk about the blessings the habit of prayer brings to one's life.

- b. Building on strength and resisting the urge to focus on weakness

An animator wishing to form a junior youth group for the first time did not know how to introduce the program to parents. All he would do was to approach a home and ask, "Do you have twelve year olds here?" Knowing that he was more at ease with younger people, the coordinator decided to help him in his attempts to meet junior youth and establish friendships with them. This assisted the animator in gaining confidence and soon he was able to form a group. In time he also learned to discuss the program with parents.

- c. Conveying hope and optimism when a friend is facing difficulty on the path of service

- d. Reflecting with a friend on the nature of his or her contributions, mindful not to elevate the ego

- e. Listening attentively when a friend speaks of his or her experience

- f. Reinforcing the habit of identifying the spiritual principles relevant to each situation

- g. Communicating to a friend confidence in the ever-present assistance vouchsafed by the Concourse on high

- h. Helping a friend to avoid feelings of disappointment when results do not match initial expectations and to take joy, instead, from the act of service itself

- i. Helping a friend to see stumbling blocks as stepping stones to progress

- j. Helping a friend seek coherence between the spiritual and material dimensions of his or her life

- k. Conveying a vision of progress that takes into account the dialectic of crisis and victory

1. Serving joyfully alongside a friend

Thus far we have thought about the significance of encouragement as it relates to two friends who are pursuing a path of service together. We should now call to mind what we read in the first section of this unit, that such a path is not to be experienced by merely one or two individuals but by scores upon scores, for it belongs to the community. This implies that the community, too, has to be concerned with the question of encouragement. It suggests that an environment has to be created in which every member is encouraged to serve to the best of his or her ability. This demands, in turn, vigilance on the part of all, if certain kinds of habits are not to form in the community inadvertently. Below are examples of such habits and tendencies; you may wish to identify a few more. The tendency to

- dwell on shortcomings
- criticize the smallest mistakes
- create too many rules
- belittle the worth of an action by comparing it with another
- bring up some negative experience from the past whenever enthusiasm starts to grow for a course of action
- romanticize the ways of the past
- yield to apathy and passivity
- ---
- ---
- ---
- ---

Among the habits we all have to learn to avoid are those that breed paternalism, a trait which both the individual and the community can possess. Care needs to be exercised, then, by every community if, in the name of encouragement, paternalism is not to become a characteristic of its culture. Paternalism begins with acts of encouragement but ends up disempowering people. Discuss in your group how this happens.

You will find it highly beneficial to end this exploration into the nature of encouragement by reflecting on the following passage from a message dated 29 December 2015 addressed by the Universal House of Justice to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors:

“Of course, it is not the provision of training by itself that brings about progress. Efforts to build capacity fall short if arrangements are not swiftly made to accompany individuals into the arena of service. An adequate level of support extends far beyond encouraging words. When preparing to take on an unfamiliar task, working alongside a person with some experience increases consciousness of what is possible. An assurance of practical help can give a tentative venturer the courage to initiate an activity for the first time. Souls then advance their understanding together, humbly sharing the insights each possesses at a given moment and eagerly seeking to learn from fellow wayfarers on the path of service. Hesitation recedes and capacity develops to the point where an individual can carry out activities independently and, in turn, accompany others on the same path.”¹⁷

SECTION 13

A couple of days before the first gathering of the junior youth, who by now number ten, Monica and Rodrigo have come together to discuss what the group might accomplish in its initial meetings. Rodrigo is excited but nervous; he wants to plan the first meeting in every detail. “My grandmother loves to say,” he mentions, “to fail to prepare is to prepare to fail!” Monica, of course, recognizes the importance of making a well-thought-out plan. At the same time, she is aware of the need for flexibility: in the early stage of the development of a group there are so many factors that cannot be anticipated, and one has to respond to circumstances as they arise. She has learned that planning and action cannot be sharply separated from one another. Action flows from a good understanding of the concepts that guide it and improves with experience. “Let us think a little about what we hope will be achieved in the first three or four meetings,” she suggests. Rodrigo, calling to mind what he studied in Book 5, responds: “Our conversations will enable us to learn about the members of the group, their talents, inclinations, hopes, and ideas, and will help them organize in their minds the activities they undertake into a coherent whole.” “Then, we need to steer conversations so as to achieve this aim,” adds Monica. She goes on to mention other important aims: to build a common vision and to create an environment of mutual love and respect that will characterize the future gatherings of the junior youth group.

Monica and Rodrigo decide to examine together the section at the end of Book 5 that outlines some important concepts for these conversations, such as “excellence” and “service”, and points to fruitful approaches to be adopted by the animator. As they do so,

they discuss the significance of the recommended themes carefully. They also come up with a mental picture of how the first meeting may unfold. Throughout their consultation, Monica notices Rodrigo's preoccupation with minute details. He keeps thinking of the many questions the junior youth may ask and wonders how he would answer them; he makes a list of activities and tries to fix a time for each. Monica does not see a need to say anything about this tendency, even in general terms, for she does not want to dampen Rodrigo's enthusiasm. She knows that with experience he will overcome his nervousness and will attain the clarity of mind that is necessary if he is to assist the junior youth in achieving the full potential of every occasion they are together. The last part of their conversation is about logistics and the materials they will need. Rodrigo decides to bring a board, large pieces of paper, and pens. Monica offers to bring copies of *Breezes of Confirmation* as well as some snacks. Before they part, they say prayers for the junior youth and their families.

The next day Rodrigo and Monica arrive at Sergio's home and are greeted by him and his parents. Soon the rest of the junior youth arrive. Everyone is happy to see that Paola has turned up with two new friends; they have reached the goal of twelve. This is the first time these youngsters are together as a group. Rodrigo welcomes them warmly and asks them to do a simple activity to make sure they all know each other. He gives everyone a piece of paper with some basic questions, and they all write down their answers; each one passes the paper to the friend sitting to the left, who then introduces him or her to the entire group.

Rodrigo and Monica go on to remind the junior youth of the themes they talked about when they were inviting each to be part of the group. Rodrigo is delighted to see that the youngsters have so much to say on the theme of excellence; they deliberate on the application of the concept in their lives: at home, at school, and in the community. The discussion of this theme prepares the way for talking about the activities they would like to carry out together. Rodrigo writes down all the ideas on a large sheet of paper for everyone to see. Monica explains that in all these activities they will strive to attain excellence in various dimensions of their lives—the physical, the intellectual, the artistic, and the spiritual. As the meeting advances, Monica notices that Rodrigo is gaining confidence. He had not anticipated the seriousness with which the junior youth would engage in the discussion of profound subjects. He feels he can now take the step of familiarizing them with the kind of material they will study. He talks for a few minutes about the first book and the concept of confirmation. The group expresses interest in studying *Breezes of Confirmation*; he gives out copies and a quick and joyful study of the initial lesson follows.

Time has passed swiftly. Rodrigo and Monica notice that the junior youth, although focused, are somewhat tired. They are offered snacks and soon they go to the park for a game of football. On their way out, Rodrigo mentions to Monica that the group didn't get to quite a few of the activities he had planned. Monica reminds him of the accomplishments of the day, which were by no means small. "You should have seen the first meeting of my group two years ago," she says in good humor. "Practically nothing went the way I had hoped and I was certain none of the junior youth would turn up again, but then things got better and better."

1. It is said in the story that action flows from a sound understanding of the concepts that guide it. Thus, in order to develop capacity for service, one should acquire greater and greater insight into the profound concepts and convictions that give shape to each act of service. Identify some of the ideas the understanding of which is essential for an individual who assumes responsibility for each of the following:

- a. A devotional gathering: _____

- b. A children's class: _____

- c. A junior youth group: _____

- d. A study circle: _____

2. During his life, Rodrigo will serve the Cause in many ways. At this point in time, he has committed himself to the progress of a junior youth group for three years; it is crucial for him to take his commitment seriously and focus as much of his energy as necessary on this act of service. A half-hearted engagement will not do. In a world in which people are so easily distracted and jump from one thing to another, how will Monica help Rodrigo carry out with enthusiasm and excellence the act of service he has chosen? Discuss in your group some of the ideas that the two may explore in this regard, remembering that Monica will not be lecturing him on the importance of commitment.

3. What are some of the abilities, habits and attitudes Rodrigo will develop in these three years that will prepare him for a life of service to the Cause?

4. Suppose you have begun acting as a tutor of a group of friends studying the first course of the main sequence. What are some of the ways of “being” and “doing” that you will internalize over time as you continue to serve in this capacity?

5. Suppose you have devoted a year to teaching a Grade 1 children’s class. What are some of the attributes you will have acquired or strengthened?

6. In accompanying Rodrigo, Monica seems to exercise the capacity to think at the level of concepts and principles while, at the same time, paying attention to detail. Discuss in your group why the development of this capacity is so important, say, for the coordinator focused on any one of the three educational imperatives of our current global Plans: children’s classes, junior youth groups, and study circles. What are the consequences of remaining at an abstract level and not connecting ideas with the exigencies of the reality in which action is taking place? What are the consequences of being so overly concerned with detail that conversation is not given the chance to rise to the conceptual level?

SECTION 14

Throughout our study of the various books of the Ruhi Institute, we have tried not to lose sight of the profound connections that bind “doing” and “being”. In accompanying one another as we learn together in action, we must pay constant attention to both of these dimensions of any act of service. What one does and how a given action is carried out matter; good planning and skillful implementation are clearly necessary. But we know well that the effectiveness of service is also contingent on what may be called the qualities of action. Thus, as we walk the path of service together, we must be ever aware that action must be imbued with love. Action must be pure, both the motive and the deeds themselves. To act requires courage. One must strive to act in a state of detachment. And little is ever achieved without perseverance. These and many other qualities of action have often been the object of our deliberations. The excerpt below from a message of the Universal House of Justice to a youth conference is only one among the many passages that inspire us to strive to adorn our actions with these qualities:

“Be not dismayed if your endeavors are dismissed as utopian by the voices that would oppose any suggestion of fundamental change. Trust in the capacity of this generation to disentangle itself from the embroilments of a divided society. To discharge your responsibilities, you will have to show forth courage, the courage of those who cling to standards of rectitude, whose lives are characterized by purity of thought and action, and whose purpose is directed by love and indomitable faith. As you dedicate yourselves to healing the wounds with which your peoples have been afflicted, you will become invincible champions of justice.”¹⁸

In this section we will seek new insights from a number of passages that have bearing on our present discussion. In *The Summons of the Lord of Hosts* we read:

“O Feet of this Temple! We, verily, have wrought you of iron. Stand firm with such constancy in the Cause of your Lord as to cause the feet of every severed soul to be strengthened in the path of God, the Almighty, the All-Wise. Beware lest the storms of enmity and hatred, or the blasts of the workers of iniquity, cause you to stumble. Be immovable in the Faith of God, and waver not. We, verily, have called you forth by virtue of that Name which is the source of all steadfastness, and by the grace of each one of Our most excellent Names as revealed unto all who are in heaven and on earth. Erelong shall We bring into being through you other feet, firm and steadfast, which shall walk unwaveringly in Our path, even should they be assailed by hosts as formidable as the combined forces of the former and latter generations.”¹⁹

Reflect in your group on how steadfastness may manifest itself when we accompany each other on the path of service.

In *Memorials of the Faithful*, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá recounts the following:

“One day the great Siyyid Yaḥyá, surnamed Vaḥíd, was present there. As he sat without, Ṭáhirih listened to him from behind the veil. I was then a child, and was sitting on her lap. With eloquence and fervor, Vaḥíd was discoursing on the signs and verses that bore witness to the advent of the new Manifestation. She suddenly interrupted him and, raising her voice, vehemently declared: ‘O Yaḥyá! Let deeds, not words, testify to thy faith, if thou art a man of true learning. Cease idly repeating the traditions of the past, for the day of service, of steadfast action, is come. Now is the time to show forth the true signs of God, to rend asunder the veils of idle fancy, to promote the Word of God, and to sacrifice ourselves in His path. Let deeds, not words, be our adorning!’”²⁰

What should we be ready to sacrifice when we set out to assist a friend on the path of service?

Bahá’u’lláh explains:

“Through the power of the words He hath uttered the whole of the human race can be illumined with the light of unity, and the remembrance of His Name is able to set on fire the hearts of all men, and burn away the veils that intervene between them and His glory. One righteous act is endowed with a potency that can so elevate the dust as to cause it to pass beyond the heaven of heavens. It can tear every bond asunder, and hath the power to restore the force that hath spent itself and vanished.”²¹

Say a few words about what constitutes a righteous act. How can it be spoiled by self-righteousness? Can you give an example of a righteous act restoring a force that has spent itself?

If a simple act can be endowed with such potency, how much power, we may ask ourselves, can be released through sustained, focused lines of action that define the path of service with which we are concerned in this unit? ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us:

“One cannot obtain the full force of the sunlight when it is cast on a flat mirror, but once the sun shineth upon a concave mirror, or on a lens that is convex, all its heat will be concentrated on a single point, and that one point will burn the hottest. Thus is it necessary to focus one’s thinking on a single point so that it will become an effective force.”²²

In its Ridván 2008 message, the Universal House of Justice states:

“Sustaining growth in cluster after cluster will depend on the qualities that distinguish your service to the peoples of the world. So free must be your thoughts and actions of any trace of prejudice—racial, religious, economic, national, tribal, class, or cultural—that even the stranger sees in you loving friends. So high must be your standard of excellence and so pure and chaste your lives that the moral influence you exert penetrates the consciousness of the wider community. Only if you demonstrate the rectitude of conduct to which the writings of the Faith call every soul will you be able to struggle against the myriad forms of corruption, overt and subtle, eating at the vitals of society. Only if you perceive honor and nobility in every human being—this independent of wealth or poverty—will you be able to champion the cause of justice.”²³

The above passage mentions some of the requirements of the spiritual excellence towards which all our actions should aspire. Discuss in your group why perceiving honor and nobility in every human being is essential, if accompanying one another on the path of service is to be a well-rooted element in the culture of the Bahá’í community.

The Universal House of Justice writes in a message addressed to the Bahá'í youth:

“The words, the deeds, the attitudes, the lack of prejudice, the nobility of character, the high sense of service to others—in a word, those qualities and actions which distinguish a Bahá'í must unfailingly characterize their inner life and outer behavior, and their interactions with friend or foe.

“Rejecting the low sights of mediocrity, let them scale the ascending heights of excellence in all they aspire to do. May they resolve to elevate the very atmosphere in which they move, whether it be in the school rooms or halls of higher learning, in their work, their recreation, their Bahá'í activity or social service.”²⁴

In reflecting on the theme of excellence, you will find it helpful to give some thought to the nature of mediocrity. In the context of accompanying one another, avoiding mediocrity cannot mean demanding perfection from ourselves and others, ignoring that our actions become more and more effective with accumulating experience. Spiritual excellence does not admit rigidity. What does it mean, then, to reject mediocrity in walking the path of service in the company of others?

In a prayer revealed for the occasion of Naw-Rúz, we acknowledge:

“Thou art He through Whom the ensign ‘Praiseworthy art Thou in Thy works’ hath been lifted up, and the standard ‘Obeyed art Thou in Thy behest’ hath been unfurled. Make known this Thy station, O my God, unto Thy servants, that they may be made aware that the excellence of all things is dependent upon Thy bidding and Thy word, and the virtue of every act is conditioned by Thy leave and the good-pleasure of Thy will, and may recognize that the reins of men’s doings are within the grasp of Thine acceptance and Thy commandment.”²⁵

We end this section by asking you to meditate on the profound truth that action receives its real meaning and value from the good pleasure of God’s will. Acts of service spring from the love of God and the desire to obey His commandments. Reflection on this truth helps us appreciate that “An act, however infinitesimal, is, when viewed in the mirror of the knowledge of God, mightier than a mountain. Every drop proffered in His path is as the sea in that mirror.”

SECTION 15

Accompanying one another on the path of service is not the only process through which lessons are learned in action and reflection on action. Another effective instrument for learning is the reflection gathering of a group of friends engaged in the same area of activity.

Rodrigo's junior youth group has already met four times. Throughout, Monica has lent him her assistance and, at the same time, has learned a great deal herself. During a conversation about the progress made by the youngsters, both individually and as a group, Monica informs Rodrigo of a reflection gathering to which all animators in the cluster, old and new, are invited. Rodrigo is excited about the possibility of learning from the experience of other young people like himself.

One week in advance, Andres, the coordinator for the junior youth program in the cluster, meets with Monica, Leticia and Luciano, who are assisting him with coordination, each accompanying one or more animators, in order to consult about the content of the reflection gathering. After prayers, he describes briefly the current state of all the core activities in the cluster and notes that the junior youth spiritual empowerment program has advanced considerably in recent cycles. The four of them then discuss the progress of all the groups, one by one.

In thinking about the content of the gathering, Andres reminds his friends that undertaking visits to parents is an ongoing area of learning. In fact, one of the accomplishments of the expansion phase of the present cycle has been the large number of thoughtful conversations that were held with the parents not only of the junior youth but also of the children participating in Bahá'í classes and of the youth carrying out core activities. They all agree that the first part of the gathering should be dedicated to consultation on the experience accumulated in this area since it would benefit all the animators, at whatever stage their groups may be. Knowing how much Leticia, who has been accompanying several animators, has learned about the nature of conversations with parents, Andres asks her to facilitate consultation on the topic.

They next examine the list of the participants. As they do so, they realize that the animators can be organized into three groups according to the length of their experience. They identify a relevant topic for each of the three: the dynamics of a junior youth group in the early stages of its formation, the study of *Glimmerings of Hope* and *Thinking About Numbers*, and service projects. The three collaborators will each facilitate consultation on one topic in one group, and Andres will rotate among the groups. About an hour before the end of the gathering, the small groups will come together to share their insights. Andres asks Luciano, who is part of a team composing and gathering songs that reflect the nature of the spiritual movement in the cluster, to arrange the devotional portion of the gathering.

Throughout their consultation, Andres' humility and love make it easy for the three collaborators to participate and express their views. Monica notices how Andres has avoided giving them instructions. She observes how attentively he listens to every word they utter and how ably he guides the deliberations, helping them to see the milestones

they have reached, to identify objects of learning, and to envision the next steps to be taken.

The reflection gathering is held with the participation of over twenty animators. It unfolds much the way it has been planned. The spirit is high and, as is always the case with such meetings, there is a leap in collective understanding. At the end, Andres announces the date for two days of intensive study dedicated to the analysis of several texts used in the junior youth program. As everyone prepares to leave, Monica gets a chance to converse with Rodrigo. She is delighted to listen to the insights he has gained from the consultations among the animators. On the way out, Andres approaches Monica and asks her if she is able to dedicate a little more time to the development of the junior youth program in the cluster by accompanying, in addition to Rodrigo, two other animators who are just entering this area of service. She joyfully accepts.

1. In planning the reflection gathering, Andres and his collaborators draw on their first-hand knowledge of the progress of the junior youth groups in their cluster. How effective would the gathering have been without such knowledge, which could have only been acquired by accompanying each and every animator in the cluster?

2. A reflection gathering, when properly planned, provides a space where the lessons learned by a growing number of individuals engaged in a common area of activity are synthesized; each participant contributes to the collective advance in understanding. There are other ways through which knowledge is gained. For example, Andres could have asked each collaborator to prepare a report, and each collaborator, in turn, could have asked the animators with whom he or she is in contact to write individual reports. All this information could have been subsequently synthesized according to one scheme or another. Reports and written accounts, of course, have their place in a learning process. But would, for instance, a report written by Rodrigo to Monica be an appropriate substitute for their conversations? Could collecting and studying reports take the place of reflection gatherings among animators? What is there about the nature of a reflection gathering that makes it such an indispensable instrument of learning, one which can be applied in the context of any of the three educational imperatives?

3. What have been some of the themes of consultation in reflection gatherings for teachers of children's classes in your cluster?

4. What have been some of the themes of consultation in reflection gatherings for those acting as tutors of the main sequence of institute courses in your cluster?

5. Learning requires one or more objects. To say "we want to learn" does not mean much, unless we specify the object, or at least the area, of learning. For each of the following activities, certain areas of learning are mentioned and you are invited to add to the list:

- a. In relation to spiritual education of children, we need to learn to

– identify teachers

– train teachers

– provide teachers with ongoing support

– organize classes according to grades

- b. In relation to the spiritual empowerment of junior youth, we need to learn to
- engage youth in conversation that motivates them to serve as animators
 - enhance the quality of the training offered to animators
 - form junior youth groups in different settings
 - sustain junior youth groups for three years
 - provide animators with ongoing support
 - make service projects an integral feature of the program
- c. In relation to the study of the main sequence of institute courses, we need to learn to
- invite more and more to join study circles
 - complement study circles with institute campaigns
 - enhance the quality of the study of each book of the institute
 - assist the participants in carrying out the practices suggested in each book
 - provide tutors with ongoing support
6. Learning in the above-mentioned areas takes place at different levels. At the level of the cluster, a group of dedicated friends intensively engaged in action accumulates experience. They continually reflect on their action in the light of the teachings and the guidance of the Universal House of Justice and begin to express with increasing clarity the lessons they have learned. One may say in this context that “the cluster is learning”. But we should remember that, as this process unfolds, every new person who assumes responsibility for an activity has to “learn what the cluster knows” and, at the same time, contribute to further learning. A culture in which individuals accompany one another in the field of service, and in which groups come together periodically in reflection meetings, makes it possible for the process to advance continuously. As always, the effectiveness of the process depends on the attributes of the individual, the community, and the institutions. For example, an individual who tends to pronounce “It cannot be done”, whenever he or she cannot do something, introduces obstacles in the path of learning. Equally, if an institution becomes so wrapped up in abstract theoretical thinking—although such thinking has a place in Bahá’í consultation at different levels—

that it forgets the needs of an individual who is beginning to walk the path of service, it will have difficulty mobilizing the human resources needed for the constant growth of the community. Similarly, a community in which there are traces of paternalism will pay little attention to the voices of the beginners and, as a result, the flow of knowledge will be interrupted. These three negative examples have been given only to underscore the need for appropriate habits and approaches to be adopted so that accumulated knowledge flows among the three protagonists of the Plan in a cluster. You may decide to identify and discuss in your group some of the positive attributes that make this flow possible.

7. We should remember, of course, that the learning process with which we are concerned is not limited to the level of the cluster. Regional, national, and international institutions systematize, at the corresponding levels, the knowledge generated at the grassroots. Subsequently, the friends in each cluster benefit from what is being learned globally. Your group may now wish to go back to the areas of learning identified in Exercise 5 and say a few words about what a cluster with which you are familiar “knows” at this point about each one.

SECTION 16

Our story until now has presented two kinds of situations in which a culture of learning manifests itself: as two friends accompany each other in action, and as a group of people engaged in the same area of activity come together to reflect on their experience. In this section, we will explore the question of learning in a very general context, knowing that we will come back to this theme later in the unit. In recent decades, the Universal House of Justice has given the Bahá'í world a great deal of guidance in relation to the posture of learning that must distinguish the community as it pursues successive global Plans. Let us examine a few paragraphs from one of the messages of the House of Justice, in this case to the Bahá'ís of Iran, which describes the dynamics of learning in the overall context of contributing to an ever-advancing civilization:

“The question that occupies the worldwide Bahá'í community, then, is how it can best contribute to the civilization-building process as its resources increase. It sees two dimensions to its contribution. The first is related to its own growth and development, and the second to its involvement in society at large.

“Regarding the first, Bahá'ís across the globe, in the most unassuming settings, are striving to establish a pattern of activity and the corresponding administrative structures that embody the principle of the oneness of humankind and the convictions underpinning it, only a few of which are mentioned here as a means of illustration: that the rational soul has no gender, race, ethnicity or class, a fact that renders intolerable all forms of prejudice, not the least of which are those that prevent women from fulfilling their potential and engaging in various fields of endeavor shoulder to shoulder with men; that the root cause of prejudice is ignorance, which can be erased through educational processes that make knowledge accessible to the entire human race, ensuring it does not become the property of a privileged few; that science and religion are two complementary systems of knowledge and practice by which human beings come to understand the world around them and through which civilization advances; that religion without science soon degenerates into superstition and fanaticism, while science without religion becomes the tool of crude materialism; that true prosperity, the fruit of a dynamic coherence between the material and spiritual requirements of life, will recede further and further out of reach as long as consumerism continues to act as opium to the human soul; that justice, as a faculty of the soul, enables the individual to distinguish truth from falsehood and guides the investigation of reality, so essential if superstitious beliefs and outworn traditions that impede unity are to be eliminated; that, when appropriately brought to bear on social issues, justice is the single most important instrument for the establishment of unity; that work performed in the spirit of service to one's fellow human beings is a form of prayer, a means of worshipping God. Translating ideals such as these into reality, effecting a transformation at the level of the individual and laying the foundations of suitable social structures, is no small task, to be sure. Yet the Bahá'í community is dedicated to the long-term process of learning that this task entails, an enterprise in which increasing numbers from all walks of life, from every human group, are invited to take part.”²⁶

In the passage below, the House of Justice identifies some of the questions that the process of learning must address:

“Numerous, of course, are the questions that the process of learning, now under way in all regions of the world, must address: how to bring people of different backgrounds together in an environment which, devoid of the constant threat of conflict and distinguished by its devotional character, encourages them to put aside the divisive ways of a partisan mindset, fosters higher degrees of unity of thought and action, and elicits wholehearted participation; how to administer the affairs of a community in which there is no ruling class with priestly functions that can lay claim to distinction or privilege; how to enable contingents of men and women to break free from the confines of passivity and the chains of oppression in order to engage in activities conducive to their spiritual, social and intellectual development; how to help youth navigate through a crucial stage of their lives and become empowered to direct their energies towards the advancement of civilization; how to create dynamics within the family unit that lead to material and spiritual prosperity without instilling in the rising generations feelings of estrangement towards an illusory ‘other’ or nurturing any instinct to exploit those relegated to this category; how to make it possible for decision making to benefit from a diversity of perspectives through a consultative process which, understood as the collective investigation of reality, promotes detachment from personal views, gives due importance to valid empirical information, does not raise mere opinion to the status of fact or define truth as the compromise between opposing interest groups. To explore questions such as these and the many others certain to arise, the Bahá’í community has adopted a mode of operation characterized by action, reflection, consultation and study—study which involves not only constant reference to the writings of the Faith but also the scientific analysis of patterns unfolding. Indeed, how to maintain such a mode of learning in action, how to ensure that growing numbers participate in the generation and application of relevant knowledge, and how to devise structures for the systemization of an expanding worldwide experience and for the equitable distribution of the lessons learned—these are, themselves, the object of regular examination.”²⁷

The two passages quoted above merit ongoing reflection. For the purpose of our explorations today, reread them in your group and then identify and discuss some of the main points. Once you feel you have a good grasp of the content of the two passages, turn to the second and look again at the questions the House of Justice presents as examples of objects of learning at this level of generality, questions that Bahá’ís are examining in “the most unassuming settings” across the globe. Consider the process of learning already unfolding in the cluster in which you reside or one with which you are well familiar. How is each of the questions being addressed, that is,

- in relation to bringing people of different backgrounds together: _____

-
-
- in relation to the administration of the affairs of the community: _____

 - in relation to the empowerment of youth: _____

 - in relation to dynamics within the family unit: _____

 - in relation to decision making: _____

SECTION 17

Events take an unexpected turn in the weeks following the animator reflection gathering. At first, Rodrigo, overflowing with enthusiasm, dedicates enormous energy to the now well-established junior youth group with which he is working. Five meetings of the entire group are held in three weeks, and he manages to hold informal conversations practically with every member, forging deeper bonds of friendship. The study of *Breezes of Confirmation* advances rapidly, and a service project begins to be formulated. Then, all of

a sudden, Rodrigo cancels a group meeting and misses the next. Monica, who is worried about her friend, tries to see him, but he finds an excuse to avoid her. She is anxious, and her mind is flooded with unpleasant thoughts. “I should have seen it coming. How could I have been taken in by all that enthusiastic talk? Maybe he was simply attracted to the idea of doing something new, and the excitement has worn off. Or maybe I did something wrong. Was I too hard on him? No, the opposite, I failed to strengthen his sense of duty. But then, what if he never had it in him to serve effectively as an animator? I should have noticed the signs earlier. Did I completely misread the degree of his sincerity?” Thoughts like these come to her mind, as if from nowhere, but she reasons against them and does her best to set them aside the moment they appear. There is too much evidence speaking in favor of Rodrigo’s sincerity and desire to serve. A talk with Andres reassures her; she is determined not to lose confidence in her friend. Prayer helps, so Monica prays and prays.

A week goes by during which Monica tries several times to sit with Rodrigo and have a heart-to-heart conversation. Another week passes, and he is still distant; “just hanging around with my friends” is his usual response. Then as suddenly as the episode began, it comes to an end. One day, during the social part of the Nineteen Day Feast, Monica notices that Rodrigo is his old self again. “I am ready,” he tells her, somewhat sorry but not overly upset. “It was too much for me,” he says. “I didn’t know what to do with so much responsibility. I took time off. But don’t worry. I feel strong again.” Seeing that she is happy but puzzled, he smiles and reminds her cheerfully: “I am only seventeen, you know.”

Crises of this kind are bound to occur in our lives as we walk the path of service in the company of others. In the next section, we will try to look into the nature of certain forces—among them suspicion and estrangement—which tend to exert themselves at such times, and the powers that must counteract them. For now, let us address a few questions related to the efforts of institute coordinators and their collaborators to assist their friends in carrying out acts of service.

1. As expected, faced with a crisis she could not foresee, Monica went to Andres asking for advice. What kind of advice do you think she received from him that reassured her?

2. To assist others, one should be able to put oneself in their place. For all of us, responsibility becomes overwhelming from time to time. Rodrigo somehow managed in this case to work through his crisis by himself. Had he confided in Monica, she would have been able to help him. What might Monica have said to him, if the opportunity had arisen?

3. Monica had the wisdom not to push Rodrigo into a corner. She sought him out but did not force him into a soul-searching conversation. As we accompany one another, we must have faith that we each have the desire and ability to overcome crises. At the same time, there are occasions when we need the support and advice of a friend. Consider with the other members of your group how we should go about deciding whether to leave a friend to sort out his or her personal difficulties or to offer advice and assistance.

4. It is only natural that we should feel a great deal of excitement at the beginning of any act of service we undertake, but what is needed for continuity of action is commitment based on a deepening understanding of Bahá'u'lláh's vision for humanity. In the story we see a young man firming up his commitment as he overcomes a small crisis. In walking the path of service together, how can we help one another transform initial excitement into firm commitment?

5. In one's efforts to assist a friend in carrying out an act of service, one must be aware of the kind of difficulties that could easily arise. A negative comment from a parent can discourage a teacher of children, the behavior of a single junior youth can disorient an animator, and a tutor can be disheartened by the apparent lack of enthusiasm of one or two study circle participants. Discuss in your group what may be some of the more challenging aspects of each of the following acts of service:

- a. Teaching a children's class: _____

b. Acting as an animator of a junior youth group: _____

c. Acting as a tutor of a study circle: _____

6. You will agree that the way in which Monica responds to Rodrigo at the end of the above episode will be extremely important. In a few sentences write what you think would be an appropriate response.

SECTION 18

When we walk the path of service together, our hearts should be filled with tender emotions for one another. What we think about our friends affects them, even if our thoughts are not expressed explicitly in words or deeds. Constant effort is thus needed to cleanse the mind from the slightest hint of craftiness and suspicion, from scorn and contempt, from the desire to dominate, and from any trace of paternalism. In the account in the previous section, suspicion did at times creep into Monica's mind, but she managed to banish it quickly each time. In this

section, let us go beyond our story line and explore in general some of our thoughts and feelings as we accompany one another in the field of service.

We are trained by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá to walk in the ways of love and cooperation, and the standard He sets for us is high indeed. Reminding us of Bahá’u’lláh’s statement that we are the fruits of one tree and the leaves of one branch, He explains:

“For this reason must all human beings powerfully sustain one another and seek for everlasting life; and for this reason must the lovers of God in this contingent world become the mercies and the blessings sent forth by that clement King of the seen and unseen realms.”²⁸

In one of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s talks, He refers to the concept of the oneness of humankind in the following way:

“Every human creature is the servant of God. All have been created and reared by the power and favor of God; all have been blessed with the bounties of the same Sun of divine truth; all have quaffed from the fountain of the infinite mercy of God; and all in His estimation and love are equal as servants. He is beneficent and kind to all. Therefore, no one should glorify himself over another; no one should manifest pride and superiority towards another; no one should look at another with scorn and contempt; and no one should deprive or oppress a fellow creature.”²⁹

We should remember, then, that, immersed in the ocean of God’s mercy, we walk together the path of service. On this path, we are asked “to be the Lord’s mercy to man; to be the Lord’s grace.” We are expected to be “the helpers of every victim of oppression, the patrons of the disadvantaged.” We are to be “sincerely kind, not in appearance only”, and to pay “no heed to aversion and rejection”, not even to “disdain, hostility” and “injustice”. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá urges us to “engender that tenderness which cometh from Heaven, and bestow love in the spirit upon all humankind.” “They must sacrifice themselves for their friends,” is His admonition to us all, “and wish good fortune to their foes.”

In our endeavor to achieve such a state of being, we are, of course, aware of the adverse forces that assail us from every side. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá was mindful of these forces when calling the believers to noble heights. “The world is wrapped in the thick darkness of open revolt and swept by a whirlwind of hate”, He remarked. “The dark night of hate hath taken over, and the light of good faith is blotted out”, He mentioned in another passage. In a letter written by the Universal House of Justice to a National Spiritual Assembly, it is stated that the principal cause of the suffering, “which one can witness wherever one turns, is the corruption of human morals and the prevalence of prejudice, suspicion, hatred, untrustworthiness, selfishness and tyranny among men.” In the arena of service, then, we must do our utmost to resist so many of the habits of mind and heart that are prevalent in society today.

You may recall ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s warning that “souls are inclined toward estrangement”. He tells us that

“estrangement and alienation of things lead to disturbance and annihilation. Through affinity and attraction all living things like plants, animals and men come

into existence, while division and discord bring about decomposition and destruction.”³⁰

As to the causes of estrangement, that which conduces to separation, according to ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, “emanates from the purposes of self”. And, to overcome this condition, we are told:

“Were it not for the love of God, discord and division would not be transmuted into fellowship. Were it not for the love of God, estrangement would not give way to unity. Were it not for the love of God, the stranger would not become the friend. Indeed, love in the human world is a ray of the love of God and a reflection of the grace of His bounty.”³¹

With these quotations in mind, your group may now wish to engage in a discussion of the causes of estrangement among friends. Why do warm relations of fellowship all of a sudden change into the coldness of alienation? What are some of the practical steps that reverse the “falling out” of friends?

Estrangement is often accompanied by suspicion. “Take heed that your words be purged from idle fancies and worldly desires and your deeds be cleansed from craftiness and suspicion” is Bahá’u’lláh’s counsel to us. What we are being asked, of course, is not to be naïve, an easy prey to deception. The spiritual eye should be able to distinguish truth from falsehood. But to routinely suspect people’s motivation, to see selfish intentions where there are none, to feel manipulated when receiving loving and sincere assistance—these are the signs of a culture of cynicism that denies even the possibility of purity and selflessness. Your group may wish to examine the nature of some of the thoughts and feelings that open up the mind to baseless suspicion. Is there a tendency in human beings, you may ask yourselves, for example, to attribute some of their own undesirable intentions to others? How self-righteousness reinforces the erroneous judgments of a suspicious mind is another question you may ask.

Our deliberations in this section should convince you that, in accompanying each other on a path of service, we have to guard ourselves against the dangers of estrangement and suspicion, not just in abstract, but in the way we relate and communicate with one another. We should strive not to look for and dwell on the negative. The remedy for bitterness is an abundance of sweetness. Thus we fix our gaze on the future of the communities we are trying to build, firm in the conviction that through God's mercy the potential of every one of His servants will be realized. The passage below written by the Universal House of Justice provides an indication of what is required:

“Faith in the capacity of every individual who shows a desire to serve will prove essential to the efforts of those who are to elicit from the believers wholehearted participation in the Plan. Unqualified love free of paternalism will be indispensable if they are to help turn hesitation into courage born of trust in God and transform a yearning for excitement into a commitment to long-term action.”³²

The following words of Bahá'u'lláh resonate in our souls:

“Beseech ye the one true God to grant that ye may taste the savor of such deeds as are performed in His path, and partake of the sweetness of such humility and submissiveness as are shown for His sake. Forget your own selves, and turn your eyes towards your neighbor. Bend your energies to whatever may foster the education of men. Nothing is, or can ever be, hidden from God. If ye follow in His way, His incalculable and imperishable blessings will be showered upon you. This is the luminous Tablet, whose verses have streamed from the moving Pen of Him Who is the Lord of all worlds. Ponder it in your hearts, and be ye of them that observe its precepts.”³³

SECTION 19

The next time Andres meets with Monica and his other two close collaborators, he invites them to a gathering being organized by Lua, the institute coordinator for the entire region. The cluster coordinator for children's classes and the one for study circles will also be present, together with a few of their collaborators. The purpose of the gathering is to consult on the progress of their collective endeavor. Since their cluster is one of several associated with a nearby site for the dissemination of learning about the junior youth program, the resource person, Alfaro, has been invited to join them as well. The site has been in operation for a few years now, and Andres and his fellow coordinators responsible for the junior youth program serving in other clusters attached to the site occasionally attend training seminars there. Monica is excited to take part in the meeting with Lua and Alfaro, which, she knows from recent conversations with Andres, is a sign that their cluster is ready to make another significant advance forward.

The gathering begins with a simple breakfast. Afterwards, Lua introduces the participants, a few of whom are meeting one another for the first time, and briefly describes the area of service in which they are each engaged. She introduces Alfaro last and invites him to speak about the experience of the learning site.

“When our cluster was identified to serve as a learning site by the Office of Social and Economic Development at the World Centre,” Alfaro starts, “we actually had only a few junior youth groups. But we had focused our energies over the course of the preceding year on learning how to sustain them and had, by then, acquired the capacity to do so. Of course, our study of Book 5 had assured us of the potential of twelve to fifteen year olds. Still, we had to witness this reality with our own eyes. We had to learn to speak with them in an appropriate way and not treat them as children. The junior youth texts helped us a great deal, providing us with the proper language and examples of some pertinent concepts. Andres, you may remember that, in the first seminar you attended, we shared with the participants the insights we had gained.”

“I do remember,” responds Andres. “It is interesting how difficult certain tasks appear to be until sufficient experience has been gathered and reflected upon. Nowadays it is second nature to us to assist animators in sustaining their junior youth groups.”

“As a learning site,” Alfaro continues, “we were given the challenge of increasing substantially the number of junior youth groups in the network of clusters attached to the site. Soon we discovered that the pyramid of human resources in place was not robust enough; we lacked a pool of young people who could be trained as animators and enable us to respond adequately to the immense receptivity of junior youth to the program. We had to look to the wider society for potential animators, and we found them as we learned to engage youth of different backgrounds in conversation on several significant themes. Among them were the concept of a twofold moral purpose, the centrality of service to the achievement of one’s purpose, the necessity of aligning one’s thoughts and actions with constructive forces while resisting the forces of disintegration tearing at the fabric of society, and the nature of early adolescence as a decisive period in the life of an individual, during which a proper and consistent system of values should take shape. We became convinced that many young people were ready to channel their energies into some form of service. We realized, then, that building capacity for the provision of training and for accompanying ever-growing contingents of youth in the field of action should be at the heart of our learning process.

“Those of us who had gained sufficient experience as animators of groups were ideally suited to learn about how to accompany other youth on a similar path of service, first one or two and soon ten to fifteen. This capacity could not be reduced to the mastery of a series of tasks to be carried out mechanically. A growing understanding of certain concepts, already studied in Book 5 but now informed by actual experience, proved crucial to effective coordination; true friendship, encouragement, mutual trust, and faith in human potential came to form our perception of the relationships a coordinator should cultivate with and among a band of animators. And far from demanding a flawless state of perfection, we learned to attend to the quality of action, to the continuity of action, to the regularity of reflection on action, and to the articulation of insights being gained in the many instances of action undertaken in diverse contexts.

“There were other challenges that had to be met. For example, when the friends who participated in regular seminars and carried out practices at the learning site returned to their clusters, they would have a clear plan in mind for what they themselves would do. However, it was not always easy to integrate the vision they had formulated into the plans for their clusters. We had to learn to propagate the knowledge being generated through

the site in a way that cluster agencies could incorporate it into their own thinking and that communities could take ownership of a program developing at an accelerated rate precisely because it was the object of systematic learning. Lua and I, for example, visited clusters and helped strengthen unity of thought among the individuals serving in various capacities. Greater unity of thought—based on a common reading of the social and spiritual reality of the cluster in the larger context of building a new civilization—led to closer collaboration among the coordinators concerned with the three educational imperatives.”

“And, at the regional level, we had to understand,” adds Lua, “the importance of allowing the friends coordinating the junior youth program in these clusters to focus their energies on this area of service for at least three years. Because of the demands that kept presenting themselves as activities in the region multiplied, there was a tendency to pull the coordinators in different directions by asking them to do this and that. Of course, it also became increasingly clear with time that efforts to engage more and more youth in meaningful conversation, and the subsequent education and support to be offered to them, were responsibilities to be shared by all the agencies in a cluster, not just the training institute.”

“The nature of the support that has to be extended to hundreds of youth who are participating in the institute process, acting as animators of junior youth groups, as children’s class teachers and ultimately as tutors and coordinators is the next frontier of learning for us,” says Alfaro. “We will have to pay greater attention to the kind of capacity these youth need to develop in order to meet the challenges they will face as they try to make decisions about education, work, and marriage and family, in a way that maintains coherence between the material and spiritual aspects of their lives.”

A few moments of silence follow as everyone thinks about the ideas that Alfaro and Lua have shared. Enidia, the cluster coordinator concerned with study of the main sequence, breaks the silence: “Sometimes it is good to hear the history of how we got to the place where we are. Today it would be impossible to even think of advancing in our learning process without close collaboration, working as if we are one soul in many bodies, but so much effort was exerted to reach the level of unity of thought we now enjoy.”

“This pattern of collaboration, a natural outcome of growing unity of thought and action, is at the heart of our scheme of coordination,” adds Alfaro. “And we should develop it further. The capacity for coordination needs to be continually enhanced, if we are to increase our human resources progressively, guarding against the tendency to close in on ourselves. Originally, for example, we focused our efforts on learning how to raise capacity to coordinate the junior youth program only in those who were or were soon to be appointed coordinators. What we had in mind was a scheme in which one coordinator would accompany as many as twenty or thirty animators. We thought that once we had learned to train coordinators effectively, we would just build more and more capacity by training coordinators in proportion to the growing number of animators. While there is validity to this line of thinking, we discovered that following it rigidly limited our possibilities. We had to allow the structure of coordination to evolve in complexity in response to the reality of the clusters, and not be attached to one or another scheme which had proved effective in certain clusters at a particular stage. A number of coordinators began to identify experienced animators who could help them accompany others with less

experience, usually in their own neighborhoods or villages. New possibilities emerged and there was greater power to accomplish our aims as people began to work in teams to address the various tasks of coordination. After reading the message in which the Universal House of Justice mentioned that ‘the assignment of assistants to institute coordinators’ and ‘the deployment in teams of experienced friends to support others in the field’ were among the innovations introduced in order to respond to the requirements of ‘organizational schemes’ taking on ‘a higher degree of complexity’, we felt assured that we were on the right path.”

“And given the interconnectedness of all the core activities,” says Lua, “the insights we have thus far gained into the capacity needed to sustain scores of junior youth groups have helped us strengthen the coordination of the other two educational processes in the entire region. Today many of you present in this meeting are assisting the coordinators of the three educational activities in this cluster by accompanying your friends on a path of service. Even those clusters which are at an earlier stage of growth are benefiting from the rich experience generated by the learning site. What is particularly significant is the understanding, profound and at the same time practical, of the nature of coordination. To ‘accompany’ has a spiritual meaning which is being grasped by more and more of the friends in action. Initially it refers to individuals’ assisting others in acts of service, but as the process moves forward, one can perceive transformation at the level of culture. The community as a whole provides an environment that empowers the friends to overcome their challenges and sustain their service to the Cause, to lovingly cooperate, and to take joy in the accomplishments of their fellow workers. And in some of the advanced clusters Alfaro and I have visited, we have noted how admirably the Local Spiritual Assemblies have fostered this environment in those communities where the number of activities has grown substantially.”

“There is one other idea I would like to mention,” says Alfaro. “Over the years, we have seen how, in a few of the clusters connected to our site, the pattern of growth has gained in strength and the capacity to contribute to the collective process of learning has risen markedly. We realize that we will now need to devote a great deal of attention to the common space of learning created, so that the agencies and human resources in each of these clusters can lend assistance in other clusters throughout the region in specific ways. The cluster where you all reside,” he notes, glancing at Monica and her friends, “is fast developing such capacity.”

The ideas presented by Alfaro and Lua stimulate a very fruitful consultation among the participants, each of whom recounts his or her most recent experience in working alongside the friends in the field, whether serving as teachers of children’s classes, animators, or tutors. The range of insights generated at the meeting is impressive indeed. Monica feels exhilarated. She realizes that, in accompanying Rodrigo in his efforts, she has been taking part in a marvelous process which will enable tens, hundreds, and eventually thousands to walk the path of service together.

In the above episode of our story, we hear Alfaro recount the experience of the friends in a cluster serving as a site for the dissemination of learning about the junior youth program. That experience illustrates how working in a learning mode leads to complex organizational structures and strategies commensurate with growth. There are certain features of the process of learning depicted by Alfaro and Lua that enabled the friends at the site to deal with such complexity. Your

group may wish to reflect on some of these salient features, for example, the systematic nature of the endeavor and the flexibility of the approach, as well as other characteristics you will identify, and describe how they manifested themselves.

SECTION 20

In the account in the previous section, Alfaro makes reference to the capacity being developed in the clusters associated with the learning site to assist others in the region in accelerating the process of growth. To gain further insight into the culture of such a cluster, let us try to step back and take a look at the overall picture of activities in a relatively advanced cluster, such as the one in which our story is unfolding. What will we see?

To begin, we will surely note that the number of people who have entered the path of service has grown steadily. The study of Book 1 has raised consciousness of the power of prayer. Numerous devotional gatherings are being held each week. Visits to homes to converse on topics of spiritual significance, following the pattern suggested in Book 2, have become an element of the culture of the community. The Area Teaching Committee has been able to dedicate ample time and energy to both strengthening this element of culture and cultivating an environment infused with the spirit of devotion and service.

Those who are walking the path of service, we will further note, have been able to benefit from its structure and, at the same time, take advantage of the flexibility inherent in it. In relation to Book 3, for example, many have completed its study and carried out its practice component but have chosen not to become teachers of children; a certain percentage, however, have dedicated themselves for years to this act of service while they continued to study the books further along in the sequence and participated in various other activities within the cluster. There are also those who dedicated one or two years when they were around sixteen to teaching the Grade 1 lessons for children and then moved on to engage in other acts of service. In relation to Book 5, to take another example, we will see that there are many youth who, having come in contact with the Faith through conversations which emphasized their role in the education of younger generations, have studied the books of the institute out of sequence, first Books 1 and 5 and soon after the other books in the normal order. Some of them, having reached Book 7 and beyond, have decided to continue with the groups of junior youth they have guided for three years and act as their tutors

for the courses of the main sequence, thus setting aside for a time their service as animators. Others have chosen to devote their energies to the spiritual empowerment of junior youth, serving as the animator of one group after another. There are also many individuals, to cite yet another example, who have diligently studied the courses of the main sequence, carrying out the practices suggested in each, and who have then entered the field of service as tutors of study circles. Further, in the area of coordination, we will probably find that conditions have been created which make it possible for several friends to take on the responsibilities of coordinator full time for a few years, supported by the efforts of a growing number of tutors, animators and children's class teachers who are assisting with various relevant tasks. Your group may wish to think of a few other instances in which, without contradicting the basic structure of the path of service—according to which capabilities progressively build on one another—the flexibility inherent to the institute process is apparent.

Although, as we continue to survey our relatively advanced cluster, it will be difficult to observe first hand, we can assume that the capacity to maintain a well-defined structure, while at the same time displaying flexibility and sensitivity in response to the circumstances of every individual, has been given the necessary attention by the institutions and agencies serving there. As always, of course, the development of this kind of capacity depends on spiritual accomplishments. So we will surely note, if we look closer, that the friends truly care for one another. Indeed, the organic growth of a cluster—in terms of the size of the community as well as the magnitude of its human, financial, and institutional resources—does not take place otherwise. To a coordinator of the junior youth program, for example, the animators laboring in the cluster are not entities simply categorized as human resources; every one of them is a dear friend who is to be joyfully accompanied in his or her efforts to pursue noble aspirations, centered, of course, on the service of the Faith. The coordinators themselves are not seen as mere instruments to win the goals of a plan; conditions are such that they can continue to make meaningful contributions to the progress of the Faith after they complete a period of intensive service in one or another area of activity. It is recognized by the friends in the cluster that the youth, in particular, need to belong to a community that cares for both their material and spiritual well-being. Can you give examples of how the requisite spirit of care and loving-kindness manifests itself in the words and deeds of individuals and institutions, and in the dynamics of community life?

Another feature of a relatively advanced cluster, such as the one we are examining here, is the maturity with which the friends work together. In their endeavor to accompany tutors, animators, and teachers of children’s classes, for example, coordinators in a cluster of this kind appreciate the significance of collaboration among the institutions and agencies of the Faith. They are able to interact with humility and in a posture of learning with Local Spiritual Assemblies, benefiting from their wisdom and assistance. Their close working relationship with the Area Teaching Committee brings coherence to the collective undertakings of the community from one cycle of activity to the next. Their ability to draw on the support of the community is crucial to the institute’s capacity to act as an engine of growth. Can you say a few words on how collaboration could be discerned in the interactions among the institutions and agencies serving a cluster that is experiencing steady growth?

Finally, in the meeting described in the preceding section, Lua mentions how the dynamics created as we accompany one another on the path of service can come to characterize a community so thoroughly that it infuses the culture. In such a culture, the word “accompany” is not used lightly, and awkward phrases like “I am accompanying you” and “I am accompanying such and such a person” are not bandied about. Consciousness of “oneness” obliterates “otherness”. To assist each other, to cooperate, to take joy in one another’s accomplishments—this is the natural way of being. Can you think of some other manifestations of the dynamics of a community which has developed this culture?

SECTION 21

The account in Section 19 has familiarized us with the idea of a learning site. This is a good opportunity to pause and think further about the nature of learning in the context of our global Plans.

Learning in our case implies the acquisition of a growing number of interrelated insights into any given reality with which we interact, in an effort to contribute to its transformation in all of its dimensions—material, social, and spiritual. Learning in this sense is not synonymous with the development of a set of skills or the discovery of a series of facts, though both are needed. It requires an increasing understanding of the contexts within which our endeavors are carried out and the forces that exert influence on the reality we wish to transform. The kind of learning with which we are concerned is directed towards processes that continuously unfold and evolve. It entails the identification of paths that lead us closer and closer to the realization of individual and collective human potential.

“Insight” is a concept that is not easy to define. But our intuitive understanding of it is sufficient for our purposes; we can use it as we try to communicate to one another what we are learning in a common area of endeavor. For example, at some point, a group of friends gained the insight that, contrary to current assumptions and beliefs, junior youth are in general highly altruistic. Time and again, this insight proved to correspond to reality as the program for the spiritual empowerment of junior youth advanced, and now it is a conviction that we all share. Discuss in your group a number of other insights that the Bahá’í community has gained in its work with junior youth.

Now discuss some insights that the community has gained in the area of the spiritual education of children.

And what are some of the insights the community has gained as a growing number of people have advanced through the courses of the main sequence?

Next, write in the space below some of the insights you have gained from the study of the various sections of this unit into the dynamics of coordination in a cluster as it moves along a continuum of development.

SECTION 22

Below are a few excerpts from messages written by the Universal House of Justice. Reading them and carrying out the suggested exercises will help you reflect further on the nature of the process of learning in which we are engaged. In its Ridván 2010 message, the House of Justice states:

“Bahá’u’lláh’s Revelation is vast. It calls for profound change not only at the level of the individual but also in the structure of society. ‘Is not the object of every Revelation’, He Himself proclaims, ‘to effect a transformation in the whole

character of mankind, a transformation that shall manifest itself, both outwardly and inwardly, that shall affect both its inner life and external conditions?’ The work advancing in every corner of the globe today represents the latest stage of the ongoing Bahá’í endeavor to create the nucleus of the glorious civilization enshrined in His teachings, the building of which is an enterprise of infinite complexity and scale, one that will demand centuries of exertion by humanity to bring to fruition. There are no shortcuts, no formulas. Only as effort is made to draw on insights from His Revelation, to tap into the accumulating knowledge of the human race, to apply His teachings intelligently to the life of humanity, and to consult on the questions that arise will the necessary learning occur and capacity be developed.”³⁴

In the Ridván 2014 message of the House of Justice, we read:

“In many ways, the communities that have progressed furthest are tracing an inviting path for others to follow. Yet whatever the level of activity in a cluster, it is the capacity for learning among the local friends, within a common framework, that fosters progress along the path of development. Everyone has a share in this enterprise; the contribution of each serves to enrich the whole. The most dynamic clusters are those in which, irrespective of the resources the community possesses or the number of activities being undertaken, the friends appreciate that their task is to identify what is required for progress to occur—the nascent capacity that must be nurtured, the new skill that must be acquired, the initiators of a fledgling effort who must be accompanied, the space for reflection that must be cultivated, the collective endeavor that must be coordinated—and then find creative ways in which the necessary time and resources can be made available to achieve it. The very fact that each set of circumstances presents its own challenges is enabling every community not simply to benefit from what is being learned in the rest of the Bahá’í world but also to add to that body of knowledge. Awareness of this reality frees one from the fruitless search for a rigid formula for action while still allowing the insights gleaned in diverse settings to inform the process of growth as it takes a particular shape in one’s own surroundings. This entire approach is completely at odds with narrow conceptions of ‘success’ and ‘failure’ that breed freneticism or paralyze volition. Detachment is needed. When effort is expended wholly for the sake of God then all that occurs belongs to Him and every victory won in His Name is an occasion to celebrate His praise.”³⁵

The following excerpt from the 28 December 2010 message to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors sheds further light on the process of collective learning:

“As an increasing number of believers participate in the teaching and administrative work, undertaken with a humble attitude of learning, they should come to view every task, every interaction, as an occasion to join hands in the pursuit of progress and to accompany one another in their efforts to serve the Cause. In this way will the impulse to over instruct be quieted. In this way will the tendency to reduce a complex process of transformation into simplistic steps, susceptible to instruction by manual, be averted. Discrete actions are placed in context, and even the smallest of steps is endowed with meaning. The operation of spiritual forces in the arena of service becomes increasingly apparent, and bonds of friendship, so vital to a healthy pattern of growth, are continuously reinforced.”³⁶

In its 12 December 2011 message addressed to all National Spiritual Assemblies, the Universal House of Justice indicates:

“It is certainly not incorrect to speak of ‘training’ children’s class teachers or, for that matter, animators of junior youth groups. Institutes, however, ought to take care, lest they begin to perceive their work as training in techniques, losing sight of the conception of capacity building at the heart of the institute process that entails a profound understanding of Bahá’u’lláh’s Revelation.”³⁷

And the 28 December 2010 message explains:

“A drop in participation, a disruption in the cycles of activity, a momentary breach in the bonds of unity—these are among the myriad challenges that may have to be met. Not infrequently the rise in human resources, or the ability to mobilize them, will fall short of the demands of rapid expansion. Yet the imposition of formulas on the process will not result in a pattern of growth characterized by the desired equilibrium. Temporary imbalances in the progress of different activities are intrinsic to the process, and they can be adjusted over time, if dealt with patiently. Scaling back one activity that is flourishing, on the basis of theoretical conceptions of how balanced growth can be achieved, often proves counterproductive. While the friends in a cluster might well benefit from the experience of those who have already established the necessary pattern of action, it is only through continued action, reflection and consultation on their part that they will learn to read their own reality, see their own possibilities, make use of their own resources, and respond to the exigencies of large-scale expansion and consolidation to come.”³⁸

As is clear from the above passages, the complexity and scale of the endeavor to create the nucleus of the glorious civilization envisioned by Bahá’u’lláh will demand centuries of exertion. The habit of looking for shortcuts and formulas, the House of Justice warns us, can hamper the ability to gain insights into various dimensions of this tremendous enterprise. Give examples of a few such shortcuts and formulas, and discuss in your group why we should not turn to them as we strive to establish, carry out, and multiply children’s classes, junior youth groups and study circles—activities that we know are to contribute to a transformation in the whole character of humankind.

Accomplishments as well as setbacks can help us better understand the complex reality within which we work; reflecting on them enables us to improve our approaches. But this is only possible if we resist the inclination to reach quick conclusions from what we consider successes and failures. For example, in one neighborhood we may have spoken to two youth, neither of whom has shown interest in entering into a conversation on the themes we have proposed. How easy it would be to conclude that themes of social and spiritual import are not of interest to the youth of today or that youth in this neighborhood are not receptive. Discuss in your group other

examples of unwarranted conclusions that can be reached on the basis of one or two anecdotes, particularly when we have narrow conceptions of success and failure.

When we think about the nature of learning we should remember that we are working within a common framework. In fact, it is difficult to imagine how a group of people could learn together if they did not have shared beliefs, convictions, and approaches. The source of the framework that governs our thought and action is, of course, Bahá'u'lláh's Revelation. In carrying out the provisions of our global Plans, we turn to this source and we also study carefully the messages of the Universal House of Justice that are guiding the Bahá'í world step by step in fulfilling its sacred mission. The courses of the institute are raising the capacity of the friends worldwide to follow this guidance in unified action. They enhance our understanding of profound spiritual truths and, at the same time, help us reflect on experience. This is an opportune time to consider some of the elements of the framework which have to do with our approach to learning in action. A few examples of such elements are provided below. Discuss each in your group in light of your accumulated experience, which by now is extensive. You should also be able to add many other elements to the list.

- Our basic approach to learning about community building is action, reflection, consultation and study; acts of service are at the center of this process, demanding a high proportion of our time and energy.
- We do not view our community-building efforts as diagnosing problems and offering solutions; our concern is the development of capacity to contribute to the transformation of society.
- We are committed to long-term learning in action, although in the process we set short-term goals and work hard to achieve them.
- The purpose of learning for us is not the mere accumulation of information and the mastery of techniques but the advancement of understanding and the acquisition of insights into such matters as emerging patterns of growth, the operation of spiritual forces, and the evolving relationships among the three protagonists of our global Plans.
- We are aware of the complexity of the community-building endeavor and try to take into account the interdependence of the many processes that should advance together.
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Distinct objects of learning require of us different ways of thinking. There are certain things that we learn once and for all after a relatively short time; we simply need to apply diligently the lessons gained. Other learning goals demand persistent long-term effort and are only gradually attained. There are also objects of learning that can never be grasped in their totality, but as we reflect and consult on them in action we grow in wisdom. We should take care not to treat the latter two categories in the same way as the first, otherwise, we will tend to create unwarranted procedures to be carried out mechanically. Can you give examples of these distinct kinds of objects of learning on the basis of your own participation in community-building efforts?

SECTION 23

In the days that follow the meeting of coordinators and their collaborators, Monica thinks often about the various facets of the complex work being undertaken in the cluster. She sees more clearly than ever the interdependence of the three educational imperatives and admires the beautiful pattern of activity that the Bahá'í community is weaving. She feels a deep sense of awe at the majesty of the mission that has been entrusted to the community and is frequently moved to pray that divine confirmations may surround those who are coordinating the efforts of a growing number of friends in the field of service.

For Monica, one of the fruits of the meeting has been the friendship she is developing with Clara, the coordinator of children's classes for the cluster. During a break at that

meeting, Andres suggested that they should get together, knowing that Monica wanted to learn more about the spiritual education of children. A few of the junior youth in her group, which is soon to finish the program and begin the study of the main sequence, are showing interest in teaching children.

Clara arranges for Monica to visit one of the children's classes to get an idea of how a fourteen- or fifteen-year-old youth could assist a teacher. Monica is impressed by the reverence the children show during prayers and notices how much they enjoy singing and reciting quotations, how attentively they listen to a story, how focused they are when they are coloring, and how actively they participate in cooperative games. After the visit, the two friends spend some time talking about the education of children.

Monica wonders if all the classes in the cluster are so well organized. Clara explains that it takes a while for a teacher to establish the class routine when he or she is first starting out. During the study of Book 3, participants practice teaching a lesson or portions of it to a few children, but it is really after assuming the responsibilities of a teacher that each one progressively develops the necessary skills.

"I often ask a more experienced teacher, for the first two or three classes, to accompany someone who is just beginning," continues Clara. "In general, teachers learn a great deal from one another. When they come together to reflect on their experience, they discuss how to address certain common challenges. Through experience and consultation with those engaged in the same area of endeavor, every teacher acquires the ability to organize the class and make it an environment that is conducive to the development of spiritual qualities. It is wonderful to see how resourceful teachers can be. Many create elements to complement those given in the lesson, say, by writing a song, or adapting a story or a game originating in our own culture. These resources they share with one another. I have come to realize that I should not single out certain teachers and present what they do as models to be followed by others. Pursuit of excellence in our program for the spiritual education of children is a collective endeavor to which every teacher can contribute."

"From what I remember of my own study of Book 3, the lessons are well defined," says Monica. "How closely do teachers follow them?"

"At the beginning, very closely," is Clara's response. "But we should remember that Book 3 and the branch courses that follow it are not mere collections of lessons. Their purpose is the training of teachers. They are designed to help the teacher reach a profound understanding of educational concepts and develop the necessary skills. All of the books along the branch present to the teacher rich content for his or her classes. However, as teachers advance through the material, from one grade to the next, they are asked more and more to organize the content of each activity and make decisions about how it is to be carried out. In accompanying the teachers in our cluster, I have found it extremely helpful to examine with them the material we now have for various grades and to reflect on the progress they themselves are making as teachers."

"The same applies to the junior youth program," says Monica. "Animators become more creative as they gain experience."

“And what is encouraging is that the teachers do not think of creativity in terms of a series of senseless activities to be added arbitrarily to those suggested in the books,” Clara elaborates. “This is disciplined creativity working within the parameters of the program and focused on its aims. I should also mention that the path the teachers are treading requires hard work and diligence, but they happily make the required effort because they have a deep love for children in their hearts.”

1. A readiness to ask members of the community to carry out tasks that support specific areas of service according to their abilities and desire is crucial to effective coordination of activities, the scope of which is to expand continuously. Shouldering responsibility for such tasks, initially with some level of assistance, contributes to the development of capabilities to undertake acts of service which progressively become more complex. Consider the following individuals and discuss how coordinators could create conditions that would enable them to take the next one or two steps along the path of service.

- a. A member of a junior youth group who is about to complete the spiritual empowerment program and is interested in teaching children’s classes

- b. A teacher who has been conducting a class for almost a year and has established relationships of trust and respect with the parents of the children in her class

- c. An animator who has been serving in a neighborhood in which some new junior youth groups have been recently formed; she attends the animator reflection gatherings in the cluster regularly and has a great deal of enthusiasm for the program

- d. Two young people who are studying Book 2 of the sequence and are ready to take on some responsibilities beyond their participation in the study circle

- e. Someone who has acted as a tutor for all the courses of the main sequence and has been able to encourage the participants to carry out the corresponding practices

2. It takes time to develop one's capacity to serve, and the speed at which this development occurs varies from individual to individual. What are some of the difficulties that arise when a coordinator has a fixed model of a good tutor, good animator, or good children's class teacher in his or her mind? We sometimes find ourselves evaluating the efforts of others in terms of our own abilities—we hear ourselves saying, "But I did it without any problem; why can't he do it?" Is it helpful for a coordinator to measure the contributions of those engaged in acts of service according to his or her own accomplishments? Is it not necessary to understand the situation, the ability, and the concerns of a person at any given point on the path of service and help him or her take the next few steps? Write your thoughts on these questions in the space below.

SECTION 24

The conversation between Clara and Monica turns next to the challenges of forming classes for distinct age groups in different parts of the cluster.

"A most important area of learning," explains Clara, "is the training of teachers for successive grades. At the same time, we have to learn how to form more and more classes and maintain them. In a few villages and one neighborhood of the city where there are a good number of children participating in the program, we have already been able to organize the classes into three grades. In other places, our focus is on starting classes for as many children as possible, often of various ages. There are many questions for which

we do not have answers yet. For example, we don't know whether the teachers will tend to teach the same grade year after year or stay with one group of children and take them to higher grades. We need to be flexible in order to see what patterns emerge. As you can imagine, several years of hard work are before us, if we are to establish 'an expanding, sustainable system for child education'."

"This brings us to my question about the contribution the youth who are completing the junior youth program can make to the spiritual education of children," says Monica.

Clara responds: "The path of service that the training institute opens up for each individual is itself very flexible. Some study Book 3, carry out the required practice, but do not choose to teach children; they lend support to the program in other ways. As your own experience confirms, many of the participants in the junior youth program are attracted to working with children. Once, as youth, they complete the first three books of the sequence, most of them are ready to teach a children's class if they wish. This usually happens when they are about sixteen. There are other youth of this age who are drawn to our community-building endeavor as a result of conversations regularly held in the cluster, some of whom also choose to serve as teachers of children's classes. The service rendered by all these youth is vital to the expansion of this area of activity. We have learned, however, that the circumstances of their lives can change quickly and many of them cannot continue as teachers year after year. To establish a sound system of child education, friends of varied ages need to be trained and mobilized. For example, there are many young mothers, even couples, who make excellent teachers of children's classes; they can often serve for several years, at least while their own boys and girls are in the program. And, of course, there are numerous friends who, independent of their age and circumstances, become very capable children's class teachers. We are learning that, to have a robust system, we need to mobilize all of these talents."

"The junior youth program," says Monica, "faces the same challenge. The youth who serve as animators are a little older when they begin, but their circumstances are also prone to change. Yet we are trying our best to help a growing number to commit themselves for at least three years."

"In addition to what we have said about youth who wish to serve as teachers of children after completing the junior youth spiritual empowerment program," says Clara, "there is another point of contact between the two programs which needs our attention. The formation of junior youth groups gives continuity to the education of children. It is essential to learn how to facilitate the passage of youngsters from children's classes to junior youth groups. This becomes quite a challenge as the number of children participating in the program grows; in our case there are almost two hundred."

"Andres reminded us in one of our animator reflection gatherings," says Monica, "that the junior youth in our program come from two backgrounds. As the system for the spiritual education of children develops, the number of those joining junior youth groups who have attended children's classes increases. At the same time, as our capacity to respond to the enormous receptivity and potential of this age group grows, we are able to invite more and more youngsters who have had no previous contact with the Faith to join the program. Andres was telling us how important it is to help youngsters from the first

background who are now forming junior youth groups to invite their friends to join them.”

“It is interesting to hear you say that,” responds Clara. “This was a topic of conversation in our recent reflection gathering with teachers of children. We were exploring ways to help youngsters develop the attitudes that enable them to establish enduring bonds of friendship with their peers. To the degree that we are successful, they will later find it natural to invite their friends to join them in their junior youth groups.”

1. If the educational process that is being set in motion in cluster after cluster across the globe is to come to fruition, decades of continuous effort will be required. As we have indicated before, such a tremendous enterprise will demand a commitment to long-term action by an increasing number of individuals, serving as tutors of study circles, animators of junior youth groups, teachers of children’s classes, and coordinators, all striving to withstand the forces of a world consumed with transitory pleasures and short-lived excitement. The commitment to action called for represents, of course, an equal commitment to a steadily unfolding process of learning. As understanding develops through study, action and reflection, we naturally dedicate more and more of our time, energy and resources to serving the Cause. The statements below describe one friend at different stages of his or her service. Discuss in your group how much time and energy is required at each stage and how the level of commitment has to grow accordingly.

- a. At the outset, when a young person has just recently completed the study of Book 5 and has, as a result of conversations with a good number of junior youth, formed a group with some ten or so members which meets on a weekly basis

- b. Some time later, when this same animator has been guiding the group for a while, has introduced intensive periods of study and camps into its pattern of activity, is visiting the parents of the junior youth systematically, and is helping the group to design and implement service projects

- c. Still later, when this animator is assisting the coordinator to organize gatherings for the animators in the neighborhood and to accompany someone in his or her first efforts to form a junior youth group

2. Next, think of a teacher of children's classes and some of the stages through which he or she might pass in carrying out this service. Describe the effort and the growing commitment required of the teacher at each stage.

a.

b.

c.

3. Now think of someone who has just completed Book 7 and who will gradually give more and more time and energy to assist an increasing number of individuals in their study of the courses of the main sequence and their preparation to undertake acts of service. Say a few words about the level of his or her commitment at the various stages.

a.

b.

c.

4. Now, consider the growing scale of activity in a cluster, as noted below. How much time and energy is demanded of the coordinator responsible, and what are some of the tasks and duties that require most of his or her attention at each level of activity?

– Sustaining five or six junior youth groups: _____

– Sustaining some fifteen groups: _____

– Sustaining thirty groups or more: _____

– Sustaining five or six children's classes: _____

– Sustaining some fifteen classes: _____

- Sustaining thirty classes or more: _____

Finally, what is the nature of the commitment needed by a coordinator of study circles in a cluster where efforts are being made to build capacity to establish firmly five to six children’s classes and another five or six junior youth groups?

And the nature of the commitment to reach some fifteen of each?

And thirty or more of each?

There is one final point that bears emphasizing here in relation to the efforts we all exert, in whatever capacity, in service to the Cause. While such efforts are often made at the request of a committee or coordinator, the expenditure of our time and energy should never be seen as anything other than a response to the call of Bahá’u’lláh and the exigencies of the historical moment. It is to Him that we have committed ourselves. You may wish to end this section by reflecting on the following passage written on behalf of the Guardian:

“The Guardian feels that, if the friends would meditate a little more objectively upon both their relationship to the Cause and the vast non-Bahá’í public they hope to influence, they would see things more clearly. The friends are not being forced to do anything, either by the Guardian or by the National Assembly. However, the condition that the world is in, is bringing many issues to a head. It would be perhaps impossible to find a nation or people not in a state of crisis today. The materialism, the lack of true religion and the consequent baser forces in human nature which are being released, have brought the whole world to the brink of probably the greatest crisis it has ever faced or will have to face. The Bahá’ís are a part of the world. They too feel the great pressures which are brought to bear upon all people today, whoever and wherever they may be. On the other hand, the Divine Plan, which is the direct method of working toward the establishment of peace and world order, has perforce reached an important and challenging point in its unfoldment; because of the desperate needs of the world, the Bahá’ís find themselves, even though so limited in numbers, in financial strength and in prestige, called upon to fulfill a

great responsibility. They must, at all times, remember that when the Guardian makes his appeals to the friends, he is only presenting the situation to them. Each one must evaluate what his own response can be and should be; nobody can do this for him. There is no other pressure than the pressure of historical circumstances. He fully realizes that the demands made upon the Bahá'ís are great, and that they often feel inadequate, tired and perhaps frightened in the face of the tasks that confront them. This is only natural. On the other hand, they must realize that the power of God can and will assist them; and that because they are privileged to have accepted the Manifestation of God for this Day, this very act has placed upon them a great moral responsibility toward their fellow-men. It is this moral responsibility to which the Guardian is constantly calling their attention, as he too cannot but obey the compelling force of circumstances and fulfill his paramount duty of calling to the attention of the believers their opportunity, their privileges, and their responsibilities.”³⁹

SECTION 25

In their ongoing conversations, friends who walk together on a path of service share valuable insights with one another. Coordinators, for example, learn much about specific areas of service as they visit and converse with a growing number of tutors, animators, and teachers of children. In this section we will reflect on the nature of such conversations. In the case of junior youth groups, these usually revolve around various aspects of the spiritual empowerment program, particularly, the study of the texts, service projects, and complementary activities. The episode recounted below focuses on service projects.

For the past month or so, Andres has been meeting with one animator after another to learn about the projects the junior youth are undertaking in the community. Today, he is visiting Rodrigo and Monica. He begins by telling them how excited he is to witness the rapid progress of the junior youth program in the cluster. “The way service projects are enhancing the ability of young people to interact meaningfully with the community,” he says, “is highly significant.” He then asks if Rodrigo is willing to share his thoughts on this aspect of the program.

Rodrigo explains that once the group had met a few times and studied a few lessons of *Breezes of Confirmation*, the members, with a little help from him, began to observe their neighborhood closely and to consult about possible service projects they could undertake. As their first attempt, they decided to clean up the area around a field where neighborhood youth often go to play football. Initially, they just thought of picking up broken bottles and litter, but then a shopkeeper heard about their plans and gave them a couple of large trash cans, on which they placed hand-painted signs: “PLEASE DO NOT LITTER”. They went to the field at a time when the local youth would gather to play football, eager to involve some of them in the cleaning project. Everything went extremely well that day; many of the youth of the neighborhood helped them and when everyone left, the trash cans were in place and the field as clean as the group had hoped.

“Unfortunately, the joy of that day,” Rodrigo goes on, “did not last long. A week later, one of the members of the group arrived at the meeting and urged us to go to the field

right away. When we got there, what we saw was discouraging. Although some people had actually used the trash cans, they were both overflowing and the ground was strewn with litter as ever before. Apparently, there had been a game a couple of days earlier and many people had come to watch. Your visit today could not be more timely. I am trying to figure out how to help the group deal with the situation and look for some kind of solution.”

“The story you tell,” responds Andres, “is actually not uncommon. For some reason, many groups decide to clean up one public place or another as their first service project. Things always look good at the beginning, but invariably, they find out that improving the environment requires work on various fronts. In your case, you now have a possibility to talk with the junior youth about the need for creating awareness in the neighborhood that small efforts can go a long way towards improving the quality of the environment. There is also the matter of the trash cans. I think I can organize a meeting between a few members of the group and a friend of mine who may be able to arrange for the trash to be picked up on a regular basis. This is an opportunity to get to know some people working for the municipality and for opening a dialogue about the junior youth spiritual empowerment program.”

“Here we see the principle of crisis and victory working in our lives,” says Monica. “The junior youth are facing a crisis which can lead to a greater understanding of reality; based on this understanding, more sophisticated strategies can be devised to solve the problem at hand.”

“You should realize, of course,” says Andres addressing Rodrigo, “that raising awareness in the community about any set of issues is a complex undertaking, and the junior youth should know this if they are not to be disappointed again. What you need to help them understand is that they can start taking small steps and then build on them. Alfaro was telling me the other day that, in one of the towns in the cluster serving our region as a learning site, two animators who were studying a course on the environment decided to bring their groups together, because both were planning to clean up a nearby park. During the meeting, the animators analyzed several environmental issues and suggested that the members of the groups walk around the neighborhood and identify some of the challenges the community is facing in relation to the environment. In a subsequent gathering, the junior youth reported on what they had observed and discussed the kinds of projects they could undertake. One proposed that a few of them could visit his father who works for the town council. They decided to take on the task of cleaning the park as their first project, but they also sent a delegation to meet their friend’s father. That visit led to a gathering of various members of the community—parents, teachers, and one of the council members—in which the junior youth presented their observations and expressed their intention to help. The two animators volunteered to hold a couple of seminars for those interested in discussing environmental issues on the basis of what they were studying in their course. A teacher offered a classroom in the local school for the seminars, which a good number of people attended. Later, a committee was formed of parents and teachers to approach the council and ask for certain services that were lacking in the neighborhood. All this enabled the two groups to engage over time in more and more complex service projects.”

“This conversation is really helpful,” says Monica. “We always talk about our efforts in the context of building vibrant communities. It is essential, then, that we learn how to involve the members of the wider community in these endeavors. Can we go on discussing this theme a bit longer?”

The three friends continue to converse for some time. But we should stop here and reflect a little on the nature of the conversations that unfold in different spaces in a cluster where the process of growth is well under way.

1. Consider the example of the junior youth spiritual empowerment program. In the meetings of the junior youth group itself, there is an ongoing conversation, facilitated by the study of the various texts, on such concepts as confirmation, hope, excellence, spiritual and material progress, good and evil, destiny and free will, the spirit of faith and the power of the Holy Spirit. A certain level of understanding is expected when such ideas are examined in this space. For the necessary level to be achieved, occasions have to be created in which conversations among animators explore these themes in greater depth. Meetings to read and analyze the relevant texts and reflection gatherings for animators are two such occasions. On another level, those carrying out tasks associated with coordination will have to grasp the same concepts even more profoundly. This they do through their own study of the writings and through ongoing conversations with each and every animator in the cluster. Let us think about the conversation between the coordinator and an animator. There is, of course, some information about the junior youth group—its size, the pattern of attendance, the text being studied and so on—that the coordinator gathers on such an occasion. But these details cannot be the focus of the conversation. Nor is the coordinator there to evaluate the work of the animator or give instructions. The conversation is an instance of a continuous exchange of ideas and insights, and its tone is one of exploration. Your group will benefit from selecting one of the concepts mentioned above, say, confirmation, and discussing how the coordinator and the animator would explore together the extent to which the study of *Breezes of Confirmation* is deepening the junior youth’s understanding of the concept and how this understanding is reflected in their view of life, their language and their conduct. You may actually wish to construct a possible conversation and write it in the space below.

2. Identify in your group themes that are to be discussed in conversations between a coordinator and a teacher of children. Select one theme and write a possible conversation between the two.

3. Imagine a coordinator of study circles in a cluster who is visiting a number of tutors hoping to learn more about the way the practice component of, say, Book 1 is carried out. Write a possible conversation between this coordinator and one such tutor in the space below.

4. The study of institute courses plays an important part in strengthening the habit of conversing on spiritual themes throughout the cluster. In what ways can a coordinator for study circles contribute to the development of this habit?

5. In the above story, Andres is clearly aware of the importance of mobilizing the resources of the community at large. This implies ongoing conversations in many spaces with various members of the community. Can you identify some such spaces? Try to imagine

the dialogue between Andres' friend who works for the municipality and a group representing the junior youth, including Rodrigo, and write it in the space below.

SECTION 26

Enidia has been serving full time as the cluster coordinator for the courses of the main sequence for two years. With much joy, she recently accepted to remain in this capacity for another year, while she is figuring out how to continue her formal studies. Many of her happiest moments are spent in conversation with the growing number of dedicated friends serving as tutors in the cluster, and this occupies much of her time. Yet she also knows that, in addition to the multiplication of study circles, the cluster is in need of well-organized intensive institute campaigns. Whenever planning such a campaign, she has a twofold objective in mind: first, to bring together groups of friends who, already progressing along the main sequence, can take advantage of the occasion to complete one or another unit or book in a few days, and second, to ensure that at least one study circle for Book 1 begins.

For the coming campaign, Enidia has, with the help of a few close collaborators, identified several groups that would like to engage in the study of Books 3, 5 and 6, as well as the first unit of Book 8. She has already spoken with a number of available tutors and has paired up each of them with a group. Given the constant demand for more tutors in the cluster, she is also doing her best to encourage several friends who, having completed Book 6, could begin their study of Book 7 during the campaign. Meanwhile, she has been giving thought to the indispensable second objective and how to achieve it. In a conversation with Andres, she finds out that Rodrigo and two of his friends, Carlos and Alicia, who entered the institute process during a previous campaign and are now serving as animators of junior youth groups, have been talking with their schoolmates and may be able to invite several to join a Book 1 study circle. Today, she is meeting with the three to consult about this possibility. Monica is also present.

Alicia, Carlos, and Rodrigo are delighted to hear about the campaign. After a brief consultation, they come to the conclusion that as many as fifteen of their friends might be interested in participating. The three of them then decide to arrange a gathering for their friends—much like the one they themselves attended about a year ago—to deliberate on the nature of service that young people can render to the community and the avenues

open to them. The remainder of the consultation that day focuses largely on the content of the conversation for the proposed gathering.

“Our friends know that we are working with groups of junior youth, and a few of them have already mentioned that they would like to be involved in the program,” Rodrigo tells Enidia and Monica. “You will enjoy meeting them.”

“I am sure we will,” says Enidia. “I remember how special it was a year ago to meet with some five of you and to engage in a similar kind of conversation. Since then we have held one such gathering during every three-month cycle of activity, but this one promises to bring together an impressive number of youth. It is so encouraging to see how this aspect of our community-building endeavor is advancing.”

“That was a most meaningful conversation,” says Alicia. “How did you prepare for it?”

“Well, there is no way to determine beforehand how such a conversation may unfold,” responds Enidia. “What we had done at the time was to talk among ourselves about the purpose of the conversation and the general themes that we were hoping to cover. And as always, we had reviewed some of the relevant guidance from the Universal House of Justice. I have actually selected a few paragraphs from its message of 29 December 2015 and suggest that we start by reading them together.” They take turns reading the following aloud:

“A generation of youth is being galvanized into action by a compelling vision of how they can contribute to building a new world. Marveling at what they have seen, leaders of society in certain places are pressing the Bahá’ís to make their programs for educating the young widely available.”⁴⁰

“The marvelous exploits of the youth in the field of service are one of the finest fruits of the present Plan. If any proof were needed of the extraordinary potential that the youth possess, it has been incontrovertibly delivered. In the wake of the youth conferences convened in 2013, the surge of energy which was imparted to the work being carried out in clusters demonstrates clearly how the community of the Greatest Name is able to give shape to the highest aspirations of young people. How pleased we are to see that, following the participation of more than 80,000 youth in these conferences, an additional cohort of over 100,000 have joined them in taking part in numerous encounters held since then. Measures to encourage the full engagement of these growing contingents in the activities of the community must constitute a major component of the new Plan.

“The enthusiastic participation of the youth also highlighted the fact that they represent a most responsive element of every receptive population to which the friends have sought to reach out. What has been learned in this regard is how to help young people become aware of the contribution they can make to the improvement of their society. As consciousness is raised, they increasingly identify with the aims of the Bahá’í community and express eagerness to lend their energies to the work under way. Conversations along these lines kindle interest in how the physical and spiritual powers available to them at this time of life can be channeled towards providing for the needs of others, particularly for younger generations.

Special gatherings for youth, now occurring more frequently at the level of the cluster and even the neighborhood or village, have proved to be ideal occasions for bringing an intensity to this ongoing conversation, and they are an increasingly common feature of cycles of activity in many clusters.

“Experience suggests that a discussion about contributing to the betterment of society fails to tap the deepest springs of motivation if it excludes exploration of spiritual themes. The importance of ‘doing’, of arising to serve and to accompany fellow souls, must be harmonized with the notion of ‘being’, of increasing one’s understanding of the divine teachings and mirroring forth spiritual qualities in one’s life. And so it is that, having been introduced to the vision of the Faith for humanity and the exalted character of its mission, the youth naturally feel a desire to be of service, a desire to which training institutes swiftly respond. Indeed, releasing the capacity of the youth is, for each training institute, a sacred charge. Yet fostering that capacity as it develops is a responsibility of every institution of the Cause. The readiness youth demonstrate to take initiative, whatever lines of action they choose, can obscure the fact that they need sustained support from institutions and agencies in the cluster beyond the early steps.

“Youth also support each other in this regard, coming together in groups to engage in further study and discuss their service, to reinforce one another’s efforts and build resolve, looking to ever extend the circle of friendship more widely. The encouragement offered in this way by a network of peers provides young people with a much-needed alternative to those siren voices that beckon towards the snares of consumerism and compulsive distractions, as well as a counter to the calls to demonize others. It is against this backdrop of enervating materialism and splintering societies that the junior youth program reveals its particular value at this time. It offers the youth an ideal arena in which to assist those younger than themselves to withstand the corrosive forces that especially target them.

“As youth advance along the path of service, their endeavors are integrated seamlessly into the activities of the cluster, and as a consequence, the entire community thrives as a cohesive whole. Reaching out to the families of young people is a natural way of strengthening community building. Institutions and agencies are being challenged to increase their own capacity in order to find ways of systematically realizing the potential of the youth. With a greater awareness of this age group’s circumstances and dynamics, they are able to plan accordingly—for instance, providing opportunities for youth to study courses intensively, perhaps immediately upon the conclusion of a youth gathering. The infusion of energy from a vibrant band of youth allows the tempo of the work within the cluster to be accelerated.”⁴¹

“This is amazing,” exclaims Rodrigo. “There is so much about young people like us. The House of Justice knows us so well.”

Enidia does not respond; the joy of seeing the youth draw closer to the House of Justice overwhelms her.

“Yes, it certainly does know our true potential,” says Monica. “The message talks about youth becoming galvanized by a vision of how they can contribute to building a new world. Should we not try to help your friends reach such a vision?”

“I don’t think that can be achieved in one meeting. But I do remember getting glimpses of such a vision during our first conversation,” is Alicia’s response.

“And we did feel motivated,” adds Carlos.

“There are two particular things I remember well from that first meeting,” continues Alicia. “When some of you spoke, you were explaining ideas I had thought about but had never found words to express. Then, there was the sense of confidence, or at least its beginnings, that I could actually do something for the progress of our community.”

“Over this past year,” says Carlos, “especially after completing Book 5, I have gradually become more aware of how much change is needed in the world. But you didn’t dwell on the problems of the world, and I really appreciated that; you mentioned a few problems but steered the conversation towards Bahá’u’lláh’s beautiful vision of a new world and how we could all participate in building it. I think if you had talked too much about the negative, the meeting would have been gloomy; I certainly wouldn’t have become as enthusiastic.”

Rodrigo turns to Monica with a smile and says: “Monica, you also attended that meeting with us a year ago. You were somewhat quiet throughout most of the meeting, but you did speak at one point about the great opportunity we had to educate the younger generation. When you described your experience as an animator, I felt truly inspired. Who would have thought that you would be helping me to take the first steps towards becoming an animator myself!”

Carlos and Alicia are both nodding their heads. “That is the part of the conversation at the gathering with our friends to which I may be able to contribute,” says Carlos. “Although I understand concepts like the twofold moral purpose, I would find it difficult to say much about them. But, about the group of junior youth for which I am serving as an animator, I could talk forever.”

With Carlos’ comment, the consultation turns naturally to the exploration of possible themes to be addressed in the youth gathering. Drawing on Book 5, on the material prepared for the 2013 youth conferences called by the Universal House of Justice, and on a few other sources, Enidia has made a small compilation of passages on the following themes: the period of youth; the twofold moral purpose and the relationship between personal and social transformation; the constructive and destructive forces operating in society; material and spiritual progress; service to the community; educating younger generations; early adolescence as a crucial stage of life; the institute and the educational process it promotes. The group has a lively discussion, and Enidia comes away from the meeting in high spirits.

1. In the above episode, we begin to see how a rise in capacity to engage in meaningful conversation with youth in different settings is crucial to the continued expansion of the educational process the training institute sets in motion in a cluster. Here is an

opportunity for you and the other members of your group to think together about the nature of this capacity and about the spiritual themes that, as the House of Justice notes, tap “the deepest springs of motivation”. As a first step, it should not be difficult for your group, bearing Enidia’s list in mind and using sources readily available to you, to put together some passages on the themes she has identified. Once you have done so, you could undertake a thorough exploration of each theme. It may well take some time for your group to carry out these explorations, especially if you decide to go a step further and engage in a corresponding process of action and reflection. In that case, every member could actually hold a conversation with some youth on the proposed themes, and you could then reflect together on each experience.

2. Experience shows that many youth who participate in the kind of conversation described in this section become so enthusiastic that they wish to begin one act of service or another as soon as possible. This often obliges the institute to help them study, say, Books 1 and 5, or Books 1, 2 and 3, in special intensive campaigns, so that they can take up service as an animator of a junior youth group or a teacher of children’s classes. It is important to remember, however, that the progressive study of the remaining books reinforces significantly the complementary relationship between “being” and “doing” that they will seek to achieve in life. Consider the following passage from the 12 December 2011 message of the Universal House of Justice:

“There are currently two points along the sequence at which an individual may choose to follow a specialized path of service. The first appears at Book 3. From among the friends who complete it and begin to offer a relatively simple class for children in the first grade of a program for their spiritual education, a percentage will want to dedicate themselves to this field of service, pursuing in time a series of progressively more complex branch courses for teaching Grades 2 to 6. This does not mean that they will abandon study of the main sequence. Indeed, courses that make up a specialized path of service anticipate that participants are continuing to progress, each at a pace suitable to his or her situation, along the path traced out by the main sequence. Book 5, which seeks to raise up animators of junior youth groups, constitutes the second point at which a series of courses branch out.”⁴²

A little reflection on the above passage makes it abundantly clear that, apart from capabilities developed through the two series of branch courses, there are a number of attributes addressed in the entire sequence that those who have chosen to serve as teachers of children or animators of junior youth groups need to acquire—a wealth of concepts they must comprehend and many skills and abilities, attitudes and spiritual qualities, they must strengthen. Your group may wish to take the opportunity, during one or two special sessions set aside for this purpose, to examine the content of the units in Books 1, 2, 4, 6 and 7 carefully and to identify the attributes treated in each book that are relevant to the work of:

- a. A teacher of children’s classes: _____

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

b. An animator of a junior youth group: _____

[illegible]

3. During the same one or two sessions mentioned above, you might also wish to identify some insights valuable for the work of a children's class teacher that can be gleaned from the study of Book 5.

4. And what are some of the insights valuable for the work of an animator of junior youth groups that can be gained from the study of Book 3?

5. Many of the youth that we are thinking about in the context of the above exercises will eventually go on to study Book 8 and beyond as additional courses become available. Why is it important for institute coordinators to make the necessary arrangements so that, over time, the youth will have the opportunity to complete these books as well?

SECTION 27

Enidia has acquired the habit of writing in a notebook her reflections and the lessons she learns. Here are selected entries from her notebook, not in chronological order, which your group may find helpful to discuss. Over time, you may also wish to look in the writings, particularly the recent messages of the Universal House of Justice, in order to find passages that shed light on the issues with which she is concerned.

- In its 29 December 2015 message, the House of Justice refers to the centrality of the institute process in fostering the movement of populations towards the vision of the Faith for humanity. That message reads: “The friends who have begun studying institute materials, and are also investing their energies in organizing children’s classes, junior youth groups, gatherings for collective worship, or other related activities, are being assisted to proceed further through the sequence of courses, while the number of those starting their study continues to rise. With the flow of participants through institute courses and into the field of action being maintained, the company of those who are sustaining the growth process expands. Progress relies to a large extent on the quality of the efforts of those serving as tutors.” How do I, as an institute coordinator, assist in improving the quality of the efforts of a friend who is serving as a tutor? It is clearly necessary for tutors to understand at higher and higher levels the content of the institute books, and the reflection gatherings we regularly hold, in which we often examine certain sections of one or another book, do contribute to this aim. We also talk in the gatherings about the abilities we need to develop to become increasingly effective in our service. To know when to speak and when to keep silent, to allow for the full but not overly prolonged discussion of an idea, to maintain a rhythm of progress—so many of these have been mentioned in Book 7 and are frequently the subject of our consultations. But one does not develop abilities just by talking about them. Practice is required, and that is what I must always keep in mind. My conversations with every tutor should be focused on his or her experience in the field, on his or her accomplishments and challenges; I should learn to help each one of them see the next steps in his or her progress as a tutor and should not be content with discussing generalities.
- What makes a tutor capable of creating and maintaining enthusiasm among the participants of a study circle and inspiring them to move into the field of action? I wish I had more insights into this matter. A sound knowledge of the content of the book being studied and the ability to help the group advance in its understanding are, of course, necessary. But other things enter into the picture as well. To possess a joyful heart and to be able to nurture a joyful environment, to have a profound respect for each and every member of the group, to feel a strong attraction to the sacred, and to be ever ready to receive assistance from the Concourse on high—spiritual conditions such as these are indispensable. I should see if a few tutors would be willing to look for passages in the writings that speak to these conditions and share them with the rest of us.
- Things have become easier since I stopped thinking of myself as the only one available to accompany tutors in the field. There are about forty people who have completed Book 7, and we are learning to see our work as one expanding collective effort. Coworkers naturally help one another. When a study circle is showing signs of weakness, there is always someone who can help the tutor restore enthusiasm. When someone has difficulty

organizing the practice associated with a course, there are always a few more experienced tutors I can call upon to assist. I think it was a mistake to forget those who, for some reason or another, stopped conducting study circles. Last week, by chance I ran into one of these friends and asked him if he would be able to take the place of a tutor who had to go to the hospital for a couple of weeks. He was more than happy to accept.

- Expansion is accelerating, and there are not enough tutors for everyone eager to enter the institute process. In the next gathering of tutors, we should come up with a list of the names of those study circle participants who, now somewhere along the main sequence, would be keen to reach Book 7 more or less quickly, once we make the necessary arrangements. Before doing so, we should dedicate some time to consulting about the kind of “creative solutions” we can devise, without cutting corners of course, to help us achieve this aim, as mentioned in the 29 December message: “If individuals proceed through the courses of the institute too hastily, the capacity to serve is not sufficiently developed; conversely, if study is overly prolonged, the process is robbed of the dynamism essential to its advancement. In differing circumstances, creative solutions have been used to achieve the necessary balance, ensuring that, within a reasonable period, some among those residing in a cluster are enabled to serve as tutors.”
- Now that friends in our cluster can easily converse with youth and invite steady numbers of them, cycle after cycle, to study the institute courses, we need to make sure that our capacity to help these young people advance through the books at a reasonable pace develops commensurately. In fact, a handful of such youth and some twenty others who entered the institute process after completing the junior youth spiritual empowerment program will soon reach the end of Book 7, and they will need to be swiftly assisted in stepping into the field of service as tutors. I should consult with my collaborators in order to identify some four or five more experienced individuals who can join us in accompanying these new tutors.
- Whenever we get together to organize our efforts to accompany the new tutors into the field of service, we would do well to remind ourselves not to have unreasonably high expectations. Most of us are nervous the first time we conduct a study circle; no one becomes a perfect tutor just by studying Book 7. It is only over time and with experience that confidence is built, and the necessary capabilities developed.
- Those of us who are working alongside new tutors are learning all the time. Our consultation last night was so refreshing; we gained many insights as we analyzed our collective experience. It became clear that, while all those setting out to serve as tutors benefit from the assistance of a friend, not everyone is in need of the same kind of support. For example, some find the gatherings in which we review the challenging sections of a particular book sufficient preparation to serve as a tutor for that course, and they advance in understanding through the occasional conversation with a friend to reflect on their experience. Others require more. At times it is necessary to go over certain sections individually with a tutor who is just starting out. There are also those who feel more confident if someone with greater experience helps them during the first several meetings of a study circle.
- Much like the participants who advance in understanding as they move through the courses of the institute, tutors, too, build their capacity progressively to guide the study

and practice of the books in the sequence, one after the other. Two collaborators were mentioning that several tutors who are comfortable studying Book 1 with a group find it a challenge to offer Book 2. Others have confirmed the same in relation to the higher-level courses. It is completely fine, of course, if someone, for whatever reason, wishes to serve repeatedly as the tutor for one book or another. But we should dedicate the requisite time and energy to helping those friends who have the desire to develop the capacity to act as a tutor for the full sequence.

- In the tutor reflection gathering this past weekend, we focused on the implementation of the practical component of the courses. This statement from the Ridván 2010 message of the Universal House of Justice provided a starting point for our deliberations: “The capabilities of a tutor develop progressively as an individual enters the field of action and assists others in contributing to the aim of the present series of global Plans, through study of the sequence of courses and implementation of their practical component.” It is clear that the effort exerted to assist study circle participants in implementing the practical component not only enhances their capacity to carry out acts of service later on but also strengthens the capabilities of the tutors themselves. One of the tutors mentioned how closely she needed to be accompanied the first time she had to organize, through the Area Teaching Committee, a series of home visits for the members of a Book 2 study circle and how much easier she found it to make the necessary arrangements the second time. Another friend told us that he had only recently begun to appreciate the importance of the third unit of Book 2, “Introducing Bahá’í Beliefs”. He is now serving as a tutor for that book, and over the past several sessions, as he explained, the members of the study circle have been practicing among themselves how to express the sequence of ideas related to each subject presented in the unit. In between sessions several of them have been able to incorporate these ideas into their daily conversations, and they have analyzed what they have learned from experience in the study circle. This is helping them to “see themselves as active agents of their own learning”. Not surprisingly, quite a number of those present in the reflection gathering commented on their endeavor to help participants in Book 1 study circles share prayers with a few people, and everyone noted how this practical aspect of their work is facilitating the multiplication of devotional meetings in the cluster. It is so heartwarming to see how the development of certain capabilities in the tutors is contributing to the emergence of the culture of mutual support mentioned by the Universal House of Justice in its messages.
- My recent conversation with Lua was extremely helpful. I think in my haste to be systematic I was tending towards rigidity. As Lua reminded me, it is easy to create rules that hamper the expression of individual initiative, especially in relation to the work of tutors. For example, the merits of inviting people to form part of a study circle for Book 1 after engaging with them in meaningful conversation are clear. Yet, this should not lead to a rule that requires everyone who wishes to conduct a study circle to find participants through his or her own efforts. Similarly, the value of the bonds of friendship forged between a tutor and the participants of a study circle cannot be overestimated. This, however, should not give rise to a rule that every tutor must remain with a given group as it advances through the full sequence of courses. The desire to improve the quality of study circles, to take another example, can, if we are not careful, result in highly restrictive criteria that, in the end, allow only a few people to act as tutors of certain books. Lua explained so well that what we learn through experience in the field should open up more and more possibilities for action, and not be reduced to a series of rules.

Rigidity and the urge to control every aspect of the institute process narrow greatly the scope of our endeavors. But exercising flexibility is not the same as being arbitrary and haphazard. The framework that defines our efforts calls for creative and disciplined initiative. She then shared with me this quotation from a message written by the House of Justice to the Continental Counsellors: “To this end, you and your auxiliaries will need to cultivate an atmosphere that encourages the friends to be methodical but not rigid, creative but not haphazard, decisive but not hasty, careful but not controlling, recognizing that, in the final analysis, it is not technique but unity of thought, consistent action, and dedication to learning which will bring about progress.” Next time I meet with my collaborators, we should reflect on this quotation, as well as on the following one from the Ridván 2008 message: “What we continue to find encouraging is how well disciplined is this individual initiative. Communities everywhere are gradually internalizing the lessons being learned from systematization, and the framework defined by the current series of Plans lends consistency and flexibility to the endeavors of the friends. Far from restricting them, this framework enables them to seize opportunities, to build relationships, and to translate into reality a vision of systematic growth. In a word, it gives shape to their collective powers.”

- Since taking on the responsibility of a cluster coordinator, I have learned a great deal from the Auxiliary Board members serving our region. This latest meeting organized for institute coordinators and the members of the Area Teaching Committee, in which the two Board members were present, provided me with so many insights into so many things. One topic of consultation had to do with the dangers of fragmentation. The institute courses are intended to help all of us develop certain habits of mind that enable us to guard against such fragmentation, habits which we apply on different occasions—when reading the messages of the House of Justice, when thinking of the relationship among various activities, and when trying to contribute to growth with its inherent complexity. At the suggestion of the Board members, we read together this statement from the Universal House of Justice, which formed the basis for our discussions: “It is heartening to note that the friends are approaching the study of the messages of the Universal House of Justice related to the Plan with such diligence. The level of discussion generated as they strive to put into practice the guidance received, and to learn from experience, is impressive. We cannot help noticing, however, that achievements tend to be more enduring in those regions where the friends strive to understand the totality of the vision conveyed in the messages, while difficulties often arise when phrases and sentences are taken out of context and viewed as isolated fragments. The institutions and agencies of the Faith should help the believers to analyze but not reduce, to ponder meaning but not dwell on words, to identify distinct areas of action but not compartmentalize. We realize that this is no small task. Society speaks more and more in slogans. We hope that the habits the friends are forming in study circles to work with full and complex thoughts and to achieve understanding will be extended to various spheres of activity.” When engaging in conversation with tutors during the next few cycles of activity, I should ask them to identify some of the habits of mind that the institute courses strive to reinforce in us, which we are then to extend to various spheres of activity. In the meeting, the Board members drew our attention to the way certain concepts are examined in the courses in a variety of contexts and how our discussion of them serves to expand their meaning and to provide us with a more and more complete understanding of them. They referred specifically to the concept of teaching the Cause and to the wealth of insights we can gain into its meaning as we advance through the sequence of courses.

- One habit of mind the institute helps develop, both Auxiliary Board members emphasized in our meeting, is to appreciate the diversity of the acts of service that the process of growth requires. As we go through the courses of the main sequence, we give a great deal of thought to a series of acts of service, in some of which we may never engage. Thus the animator of a junior youth group, for example, has gained many insights into the spiritual education of children from the study of Book 3, and the teacher of children's classes is well aware of the role the junior youth spiritual empowerment program plays in shaping the mission and character of the next generation. Everyone recognizes the significance of visiting homes, of enriching the culture of the community through elevated conversations, of devotional gatherings that provide spiritual nourishment to larger and larger numbers of people. No one person, of course, is ever involved in all aspects of service to the Cause. But every participant in the Plan needs an adequate understanding of the mutually reinforcing acts of service that the training institute promotes and of the contributions they each make to the growth of the community.
- I have been thinking about Lua and the way she has been assisting me over the past two years. Once she told me that we should not consider as our projects the friends we are accompanying on the path of service, and I have gradually understood what she meant from her own example. She celebrates, without any reference to herself and any sense of self-satisfaction, every little accomplishment of mine. And she helps me learn from my mistakes dispassionately. When reading this quotation from a message of the House of Justice, I immediately thought of her: "Calm determination will be vital as they strive to demonstrate how stumbling blocks can be made stepping stones for progress. And a readiness to listen, with heightened spiritual perception, will be invaluable in identifying obstacles that may prevent some of the friends from appreciating the imperative of unified action." I am also learning from her what it means to offer encouragement "not in the abstract but on the basis of that intimate knowledge which is only acquired by working side by side in the field of service."
- The gathering with the youth to invite them to join us in our community-building endeavor was so uplifting. Alicia, Carlos, and Rodrigo have a most outstanding group of friends. The conversation flowed easily from theme to theme. Once we had discussed various subjects, it became clear that the youth would like to hear something about the Faith. We asked Monica to make a few introductory remarks, and she gave a very captivating presentation. Andres was also with us, helping throughout the meeting. Each time he spoke, however, I felt a little sadness in my heart, for I happen to know that he will be soon leaving the cluster. He should be happy, of course, for having nurtured several devoted and capable collaborators over the last couple of years. And he will render valuable service to the Cause wherever he may live. The other day Lua mentioned to me that Monica will be asked to serve as the cluster coordinator for the junior youth program. That is how it should be. At the end of the period of service that any cluster coordinator is rendering, there should be a number of souls who stand ready to assume the responsibility and help move that component of the educational process towards new horizons.

SECTION 28

We began this unit by examining the nature of the path on which we develop our capacity to serve the Cause and humanity and the implications of walking it. We then turned our attention to two closely connected concepts, accompanying one another and learning together, concepts that we attempted to explore in detail in light of passages from the writings, particularly the recent guidance of the Universal House of Justice. The story of Monica and Rodrigo brought to our explorations insights from the experience of an ever-growing number of friends around the world who are walking the path of service and enabled us to reflect on certain attributes that distinguish their interactions. The study of the unit has also given us an opportunity to spend some time discussing the responsibilities of institute coordinators serving at the level of the cluster and to familiarize ourselves with the intricacies of the all-important work they carry out. We now know that Monica, whose capacity we watched grow over the course of the story, will be asked to serve as the cluster coordinator for the junior youth program. But coordinators do not simply appear. Monica was assisted step by step in broadening the sphere of action in which she moved as she demonstrated eagerness and a keen sense of responsibility towards the work before her at any given moment.

The path of service described in this unit is wide; it invites everyone who so wishes to enter it. Once on the path, we each advance according to our own circumstances and abilities. The simple acts of service that mark the path at the beginning are followed by others that gradually become more demanding. This offers us the opportunity to systematically enhance our capacity for service. No one walks the path alone; each one of us is helped by others to carry out specific tasks, to gain assurance, and to serve more effectively. Encouragement is a sustaining power to be drawn upon at every step. When obstacles confront us and despondency sets in, we bring hope to one another, reminding ourselves that the bounties of God always surround us. When doubts arise and confidence is shaken, we press on together, putting our complete trust in God and in His unfailing grace.

That we accompany one another down the long stretches of this path, as we learn to traverse its terrain, is, of course, imagery evoked to help us describe the individual and collective process of capacity-building in which we all are engaged. The dynamics of our interactions as we pursue this capacity-building process has been, whether explicitly or not, the subject of intense exploration in section after section of this unit. Among the spiritual requisites that such a dynamics demands are two that deserve our final reflection here: humility and the generosity of spirit that bespeaks a magnanimous heart. The friends we met in our story—Roxana, Paola, and her mother Mrs. Ramirez; Rodrigo and his friends Alicia and Carlos; Monica, Luciano and Leticia; Andres, Clara and Enidia; Alfaro and Lua—were all imbued with these two qualities. How else could they have been able to achieve so much during such a relatively short time? It was humility that helped them detach themselves from their own accomplishments. It was their generosity of spirit that engendered the joy they felt at witnessing the achievements of others. So, too, did this same spirit enable those with experience and some knowledge of the path to avoid the inflexibility and rigidity that result from the urge to control every detail when they were called upon to accompany others in the field of service. To overlook the shortcomings of their coworkers and strive to make good every mistake, these came easily to our friends. How else, we should ask ourselves, when we know that humility and magnanimity are so indispensable to harmonious interactions, could they have been able, as the Master so longed, “to become as one”, “to follow one and the same pathway”, and “to hold fast to a single resolve”? And how, in the

absence of these two qualities, could they have been able to contribute to an environment in which their individual powers were multiplied in unified, unremitting action? “Day by day”, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá urges us in the Tablets of the Divine Plan, “may you add to your effort, exertion, and magnanimity.” Let us end our study of this unit by memorizing the following passage from one of those Tablets:

“Praise be to God that the divine outpourings are infinite, the melody of the lordly principles is in the utmost efficacy, the most great Orb shining with perfect splendor, the cohorts of the Supreme Concourse are attacking with invincible power, the tongues are sharper than the swords, the hearts are more brilliant than the light of electricity, the magnanimity of the friends precedes all the magnanimities of the former and subsequent generations, the souls are divinely attracted, and the fire of the love of God is enkindled.”⁴³

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- ²⁴ From a message dated 8 May 1985 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá'í youth of the world, published in *Messages from the Universal House of Justice, 1963–1986: The Third Epoch of the Formative Age* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 1996), no. 428, pp. 668–69.
- ²⁵ *Prayers and Meditations by Bahá'u'lláh* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing, 2013), no. 46, pp. 55–56.
- ²⁶ From an unpublished message dated 2 March 2013 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá'ís of Iran.
- ²⁷ Ibid.
- ²⁸ *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá*, no. 1, p. 3.
- ²⁹ *The Promulgation of Universal Peace: Talks Delivered by 'Abdu'l-Bahá during His Visit to the United States and Canada in 1912* (Wilmette: Bahá'í Publishing, 2012), pp. 85–86.
- ³⁰ *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá*, no. 225, p. 303.
- ³¹ 'Abdu'l-Bahá, *Some Answered Questions* (Haifa: Bahá'í World Centre, 2014), no. 84, p. 347.
- ³² From a message dated 28 December 2010 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, published in *The Five Year Plan, 2011–2016*, pp. 32–33.
- ³³ *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh*, no. 5, pp. 8–9.
- ³⁴ From the Riḍván 2010 message of the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá'ís of the world, published in *The Five Year Plan, 2011–2016*, pp. 16–17.
- ³⁵ From the Riḍván 2014 message of the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá'ís of the world.
- ³⁶ From a message dated 28 December 2010 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, published in *The Five Year Plan, 2011–2016*, p. 35.
- ³⁷ From a message dated 12 December 2011 written by the Universal House of Justice to all National Spiritual Assemblies, in *ibid.*, p. 77.
- ³⁸ From a message dated 28 December 2010 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, in *ibid.*, p. 36.
- ³⁹ From a letter dated 19 July 1956 written on behalf of Shoghi Effendi to a National Spiritual Assembly, cited, in part, in *Unlocking the Power of Action*, a compilation prepared by the Research Department of the Universal House of Justice (New Delhi: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 2005), pp. 24–25; also cited, in part, in “Guidelines for Teaching”, a compilation prepared by the Research Department of the Universal House of Justice, published in *The Compilation of Compilations* (Maryborough: Bahá'í Publications Australia, 1991), vol. 2, pp. 322–23.
- ⁴⁰ From a message dated 29 December 2015 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, published in *The Five Year Plan, 2016–2021*, pp. 1–2.
- ⁴¹ Ibid., pp. 21–23.
- ⁴² From a message dated 12 December 2011 written by the Universal House of Justice to all National Spiritual Assemblies, published in *The Five Year Plan, 2011–2016*, pp. 71–72.
- ⁴³ From a Tablet to the Bahá'ís of the Southern States, published in *Tablets of the Divine Plan*, p. 70.